Hello my love, oh I mean my rival
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Hello my love, oh I mean my rival

by K1LLERDR4GON

Summary

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>
> Phainon squints at him, trying to figure him out. But it’s not like Mydei to be obtuse, the man had always been straightforward, sometimes to an infuriating degree. With Mydei, you can always be sure he only says what he means, so Phainon doesn’t think too much about it when he shakes his head.
>
> “No.”
>
> “Nobody at all?” Mydei asks again.

Phainon, desperate to find love, begs his best friend Mydei to be his dating coach. After all, Mydei is so perfect, his opinion has to be worth his weight in gold, right?
It’s not like he ever had a chance with the man himself anyway.

As for Mydei, what’s a guy to do when his best friend, who he’s secretly in love with, asks him for dating advice? Earnestly help while locking away his own feelings, of course.

Notes

Update 19/11/2025: I swapped out the image links of the text message to custom css, so please make sure you have 'creator's workskins' turned on! I hope this makes things more accessible.

Most sincere gratitude to HSR chatbox guide by jihnari

Chapter 1: Phainon

Chapter Notes

> Welcome to my obligatory ‘everything is fine and everyone is happy’ AU. This is my humble contribution to the Phaidei pie. I initially wrote this as a one-shot and then got really carried away so it will be split into 3 chapters, with the last one being a mostly smutty epilogue of sorts.
>
> Just a note that the chapter will jump between timelines - the past where they were roommates and the present day. Hopefully both are delineated clearly.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Living in a frat house had its benefits, it was cheap, and for a financially struggling college student it… it was cheap.

It had a hell of a lot more drawbacks, in Phainon’s opinion. The smell of sweat and booze that just seemed to linger no matter how many times he scrubbed the kitchen, the discarded beer cans and bottles that nobody ever bothers to take out on recycling day, but most egregious of all must be the lack of privacy.

Phainon had returned home after a long day of assignments only to find that the door to his room had been locked from the inside.

And somebody was making noises, from inside his own room.

Very suggestive ones, for that matter.

“Wow, I thought those kinds of things only happened in movies. Your frat brothers are… interesting.” When his life is falling apart, at least he can always count on his dear friend Mydei to lend a listening ear to his moans. Nevermind, wrong choice of wording, the trauma from what he overheard is still fresh in his mind.

Beautiful, sweet, perfect Mydei, who despite his grumbling was kind enough to come and hang out in the arcade at ass o'clock on a weekday. The blonde man drops a coin into the machine slot and picks the same character he always uses, the muscled berserker type that the internet claims is hard to play, but Mydei makes it work somehow.

"Interesting?" Phainon repeats in disbelief, buttons clacking as he wastes time choosing his character until he decides on the hero, sword of light and all. "I wish I knew how to wipe my own memory.".

The game begins, Mydei and Phainon both fall silent as their fingers dance around the controller buttons, trying to get the upper hand on each other. Mydei has a more aggressive approach, he always does. Phainon knows him well enough that the best strategy is to focus on dodges and blocks until he gets his chance to counterattack.

"I wish I could move out, but my lease lasts until the end of term," Phainon sighs. He finally lands a combo and Mydei's character stumbles back, health bar sliced nearly in half.

"You voluntarily signed the lease, you just have to deal with it until it's up," Mydei replies heartlessly, eyes fixed on the screen. With a few button presses he unleashes his character's ultimate and red crystals fill the screen, shearing Phainon's health until it's almost nothing.

"You're always so mean to me, Mydei," Phainon whines, referring to both his comment and the sudden attack that almost kills his character. But Phainon plays better when he's under pressure. His fingers move lightning fast, blocking and evading at just the right moments, well-timed attacks cleaving away at Mydei's health bar.

"I want to find love too," Phainon suddenly says. His voice is muffled by the sounds of the arcade, but Mydei hears it loud and clear.

Mydei falters, his grip on the joystick slipping, missing his cue to counterattack, just a heartbeat too slow. Phainon takes the opportunity to unleash another devastating combo, quick and merciless. Mydei's health

drops even more, his blocks ineffectual under Phainon's barrage until the screen explodes into a bright red 'K.O.'

"That came out of nowhere." Mydei says. Tickets trail out of the machine, pooling around their shoes. But Mydei is looking straight at Phainon, gold eyes focusing only on him.

"We're almost into our third and final year and I still haven't experienced the whirlwind college romance I was promised!"

Mydei just raises an eyebrow at him. "The girls in the history department call you the 'Snowy Prince'. I thought you of all people would have no shortage of admirers."

Phainon snorts. It's not like Phainon hasn't been asked out before. He's popular, friendly, athletic and one of the top students in the law department. Not to be full of himself, but his looks are nothing to scoff at either, all the aunties back home can't stop cooing over how handsome he is.

But still, none of those people had stirred his heart, not even a little bit.

Trying to change the subject, Phainon says with a smirk. "You'd be surprised, but, not really. Besides, if anyone deserves the title of 'Prince', it should be you, right, Mydei?"

Mydei doesn't dignify that with a response, instead giving Phainon the familiar withering look reserved for when he's saying something stupid.

But titans, Mydei looks devastatingly good underneath the flickering, pulsating lights of the arcade. The glow of neon red and electric blue ripples across his skin, casting shadows over his sharp, red tattoos. He crosses his arms, muscles bulging and fully visible due to his choice of a red sleeveless shirt. His hair turns technicolor in the light, blonde darkening to red at the tips like blood. The arcade is stuffy, skimping on air conditioning, and the locks of hair stick slightly to his nape as he shifts.

"I'm serious!" Phainon insists, never one to back down in a competition with Mydei, even if it is entirely self-imposed and one-sided. "I mean

like… look at you! You're kind, well-read, soft-spoken, and your body is so conspicuous that even I'm jealous of it. You're totally prince material."

Mydei leans back, resting his elbows against the machine, the furrow between his eyebrows deepening. "I often think this, but there's something wrong with your brain."

To Phainon, that's as good as an admission, a victory.

It's not like he doesn't mean it. Although Phainon perhaps has the more typical characteristics of a prince, blue eyes, white hair, a charming smile that could get him almost anything he wants, Mydei is one among them who truly embodies princely qualities. He's the only person Phainon knows who is the definition of 'beautiful', 'handsome', and 'hot' all in one package. Despite his full body tattoos and the permanent scowl on his face, he has a classical beauty that people would write poems about.

Get to know Mydei a little more, and one will realize he's perfect on the inside too. Loves reading, a good cook, thoughtful and observant, skilled at playing the guitar, with an indomitable personality that never seems to falter to matter the circumstances.

Phainon is envious of him in that regard too, as he still finds himself full of insecurities and the latest one seems to be his inability to find a romantic partner.

"Mydei, I have a request, be my dating coach!" He practically leans over to Mydei's side, taking both of Mydei's hands in his.

Perhaps it's the dim lighting of the arcade, but Mydei's face seems to flush red. "HKS! What nonsense are you talking about?"

"Pleasseeee Mydei! Help me out! I really want to start dating!" Phainon begs, using his best 'kicked puppy' expression that he knows Mydei is weak to.

"Grown ass man," Mydei grumbles under his breath, but the way he's not making eye contact with Phainon lets him know that it's only seconds

before he concedes. And right on cue, Mydei sighs.

“Has there really been nobody who catches your eye over the last 2 years?” Mydei asks quietly. Is it a trick of the light or was there… hesitance in those golden eyes?

Phainon squints at him, trying to figure him out. But it’s not like Mydei to be obtuse, the man had always been straightforward, sometimes to an infuriating degree. With Mydei, you can always be sure he only says what he means, so Phainon doesn’t think too much about it when he shakes his head.

“No.”

“Nobody at all?” Mydei asks again.

“Really, there’s been nobody,” Phainon says. When every potential partner inadvertently gets compared to Mydei, they’re all bound to fall short.

“I see…” Mydei mutters quietly, something unreadable flashing over those fierce, feline-like eyes before it disappears again. “And why would you even ask me? It’s not like I’ve been in a relationship either.”

Mydei puts his hands on the controller again, seemingly losing interest in their conversation. “Come on, let’s play again. I’ll be victorious this time.”

That is true, ever since Phainon first met Mydei in their first year, they had both been single. And even if Mydei hadn’t told him, he doubted that his friend had been in a relationship before, because he doubted there was anyone idiotic enough to break up with Mydeimos. Besides, Mydei shouldn’t be settling for just anyone, any potential partner would have to be as impressive as him, at the very least.

As Phainon thinks that, something that feels like envy makes his stomach churn and bile rise to his throat. Why is that? He is certainly not that shallow to be bitter at the idea of Mydei getting into a relationship before himself. And he is definitely not that competitive… At least, he hopes he isn’t.

Phainon starts as the screen flashes with the large red ‘K.O’. Despite having a strong start he seemed to have lost again.

“That makes it 7:3, seven for me, three for you.” It was stated matter-of-factly, Mydei had stopped gloating two rounds ago, which means that Phainon must be in really bad shape.

“You look unwell.” Phainon jerks up with a guilty start. Mydei is still in the same relaxed pose, arms draped over the sides of the machine. But his eyes are sharp, molten gold tracking Phainon with the intensity of someone used to reading people closely, quietly. “Is a small matter truly bothering you that much?”

“No it’s- it’s not that,” Phainon says, suddenly very interested in the ***‘GAME OVER-RESTART?*** ’ screen. “I was just thinking.”

“Don’t strain yourself.” Mydei says dryly. “Tell me what idiotic thoughts are brewing in your head this time.”

Phainon chuckles, it comes out pretty forced. He runs a hand through his hair, messy and slightly greasy from a full day out and about. He wishes he could just go home, shower, and crawl into bed, like what he wanted to do initially before this all happened. “I just thought that I’d be kind of sad if you fell in love before me.”

Mydei exhales deeply, rubbing the bridge of his nose like he’s bracing for a headache.

“How would I even help you?” Even though he has made it clear how abhorrent he finds the idea, Mydei is still not saying no. Phainon could almost cry at how nice he’s being.

“It’s easy, you just need to give me your brutally honest advice on what I’m lacking in as a romantic partner,” if it were anyone else, Phainon wouldn’t even give them the time of day. But this was Mydei, a man who’s opinion he valued greatly. He trusted that Mydei would tell him not what he wanted to hear, but what he needed to hear.

Mydei sighs, he collects all the tickets off the floor, and dumps them into Phainon's lap.

"Let's get out of here first, this isn't the place for a conversation."

Whenever they go to arcades, Mydei always lets Phainon pick the prize. He says it's because he doesn't care about silly collectibles, but Phainon knows he has a soft spot for cute things.

"Deliverer, you didn't have to get anything for me," Mydei scoffs, the chimera keychain swinging around his finger. "I told you, you can pick the prizes."

"But I wanted to get us something that matches!" Phainon says, holding his own next to Mydei's. One has orange fur with big brown eyes, while the other has grey fur with blue eyes, the resemblance to the two of them was uncanny. "Look, it says your little guy's name is Fig Stew, and mine's Coconut Beagle."

"A strange name," Mydei huffs, but pockets the keychain nonetheless. Phainon feels a swell of pride, like a grumpy cat has accepted his offering.

"Going back to what you said earlier." Mydei says quietly. "You are perfect as you are, there is nothing about yourself that needs to change."

Phainon thinks if he were a lesser man he would have swooned at that. Such simple words spoken with such sincerity, like it was the most obvious fact in the world. There is nothing more validating than hearing that from Mydei, who doesn't bother with empty praise. And yet, Phainon finds it hard to believe, surely someone who holds himself and others to such high standards will have some feedback for him.

Mydei, for all his virtues, is kind at heart. Perhaps kind enough to say what he thinks Phainon wants to hear.

"None of that nonsense, you don't need to go easy on me. I really do want to find parts of myself that I can improve on."

Mydei's eyes soften, with the angle of his eyebrows lowered, he looks gentler, almost tender. "I'm not being dishonest, you are enough as you are now."

Phainon's breath hitches imperceptibly, but Mydei continues, unaware of the things he's doing to his heart "You are charming and approachable, with an affability that allows you to befriend even the most difficult people. You're also intelligent, even though sometimes you speak like someone who doesn't have a brain." His mouth twitches like he wants to smile. "You passed Professor Anaxagoras's class with merits, something that only 3 people managed to accomplish this year."

"Haha," Phainon laughs, rubbing the back of his neck. Mydei's praise makes him feel all light and bubbly, like a maiden in love. Is this what they call irresistible charm? Especially since he knows Mydei doesn't give compliments lightly. "You flatter me, but there certainly must still be things I can work on? Hit me with that brutal honesty you're so well-known for!"

The irritated expression is back, and Mydei clicks his tongue. It's barely audible, and Phainon knows that this means he's getting annoyed. But Mydei always humours him even when he's being an idiot, and his jaw tightens as he puts thought, actual thought into the question.

"Something you can improve on?" Phainon finds himself leaning closer to listen better. "Well, your lack of self-confidence can be vexing, you're always trying too hard to please people even at your own peril, and I suppose your sense of style could be better."

Phainon immediately latches onto the third and final part, because changing his style is way easier than confronting his self-esteem issues and people pleasing tendencies.

"What part of my style do you dislike? Is it the pants?" They're his favourite, purple with a dromas scale pattern. So soft and comfortable to wear.

"Yes, burn them, for starters. That yellow shirt as well. There is no universe where that colour combination looks good. The arcade attendee must have

thought you were one of the children."

"Alright… better clothes… style my hair… that reminds me, I have to burn my sheets at the frat house as well, I'll burn them together with the pants."

Mydei's snorts at that, the corners of his lip turning up just a fraction. It's enough to make him look devastatingly handsome. "You don't have to take everything I say so seriously, deliverer. Like I said, the way you are presently is fine."

Well, Phainon knows that, but there is still a part of him that feels he has to work hard to live up to the expectations others put on him. It is true that he's fairly popular and well-liked, otherwise he wouldn't have been accepted into the top fraternity in the first place. But Phainon can still do more, when Mydei is the picture of excellence, he certainly can't fall behind.

After all, they'd been rivals since they first met.

The blistering heat of summer prickles Phainon's skin, the sun tattoo on his neck, just freshly healed, itches in response to the sweat trickling down into the collar of his shirt. Okhema summers are a lot more humid compared to the ones in Aedes Elysia, something about the concrete jungle trapping the sun's heat, so unlike the sprawling cornfields in his hometown, that distributed the heat like a warm blanket.

His hometown is rural, the kind where everyone knows each other by name. For the last month, Phainon getting accepted into the law program at the University of Okhema was the talk of the town. It feels burdensome sometimes, to carry the weight of everyone's pride and expectations on his shoulders. It's almost a relief to arrive in the bustling metropolitan of Okhema and become just a nameless face in the crowd.

He trudges up the stairs that lead to his dorm room, fifth floor, no elevator, dragging his bags with him all the while. By the time he arrives, he's red-faced and panting, even though he's not exactly unfit.

Behind the door of his future dorm room, he can hear the sound of someone moving around, it looked like his future roommate had already moved in. ‘Mydeimos’, the roster had said. It wasn’t a name native to Okhema, so maybe an outsider too, perhaps they can bond in that regard.

And because he was raised to be polite, Phainon takes a deep breath, checks out his hair with his front camera, puts on his best smile, and knocks before turning the doorknob.

Inside, crouched on the floor unpacking boxes, is the most beautiful man he’s ever seen.

The first thing he notices are his tattoos, strong red lines over smooth fair skin and taut muscle tracing throughout the entirety of his bare arms, up his neck, and even on his face. It was… definitely eye-catching, to put it mildly. But not in a distasteful way, on the contrary, Phainon found it captivating.

The next is his absurd body, the man is dressed in a loose tank top that accentuates his bulging shoulders, tapering to a narrow waist. Phainon’s been putting in his hours at the gym and he’s pretty proud of his own physique, but this guy is just on a different level. Maybe he worked as a fitness instructor in his spare time?

His roommate notices him, eyes the colour of molten gold meeting his gaze as Mydeimos lowers his headphones, Phainon can faintly hear heavy metal blaring from them.

“Are you my new roommate? I’m Mydeimos, first year history, you can call me Mydei.”

Unfortunately for him, Phainon did not catch any of that. He was too busy staring at his face. Soft blonde hair, fading to red at the tips, falling around straight eyebrows and sharp, almost feline-like eyes. His eyelashes were long and thick, like a girl’s. A face like that shouldn’t fit a body like his, and yet it all came together naturally for him.

The beautiful face frowns at him, and that’s when Phainon realizes he’s supposed to respond.

“Hi! I’m Phainon. You must be Mydeimos.” Nevermind if Phainon didn’t hear what he just said, he’s great at improvising.

But somehow, his cheerful fail proof greeting had Mydeimos frowning even deeper.

“Mydeimos is my government name, I prefer Mydei… I just said that.” His voice is deep and gravelly, like smoke from a flame. Phainon would find it pleasant, if he wasn’t absolutely mortified by the faux pas.

“I’m sorry!” This first interaction was not going like he hoped. Phainon desperately needed to salvage this. “I'm a first year law student by the way, I hope we can get along!”

He sticks out his hand for a handshake. He doesn’t like the way Mydei is looking at him, those amber eyes almost glow in the cheap dorm lighting, like they can see right through him.

“Mm,” He just grunts before pulling his headphones back over his ears and carrying on with his task. Phainon awkwardly withdraws his hand, grimacing at the cringe of it all.

Right… that could have gone better. Mydei isn’t the easiest guy to get along with, but he didn’t seem angry, just indifferent.

As Phainon gets to work unpacking his side of the room, he sneaks glances at what his roommate is doing. Mydei, to his surprise, is meticulous. His bedsheets are tucked in neatly, military style, without even a crease on its surface. His books are arranged along the shelf standing upright, and even his stationery is colour coded. He’s so conscientious that it’s almost… cute.

“Is that a chimera? I love those guys,” Phainon points to the exposed bookmark on Mydei’s bedside table, next to a collection of history books so thick and old they looked like they were written centuries ago. “I didn’t

expect a scary looking guy like you to be into cute things. Do you know what ‘gap moe’ is?”

Mydei simply gives him a withering look, one that Phainon would become very familiar with in the weeks to come.

“I think we’d get along better if you didn’t speak.”

Despite Phainon’s wishes, he did *not* get along with Mydei. He initially thought Mydei was the kind of guy that would just ignore him, well, evidently he was wrong, because the guy was a total nag!

Phainon wouldn’t say he’s messy, after all he always cleans up after himself and doesn’t leave food on the bed, but as the assignments pile up and the social obligations increase, he finds himself slipping on cleanliness now and again.

“Deliverer, get your clothes off the floor before I trip on them!”

One time, *one time* , he had accidentally locked Mydei out of their room because he couldn’t hear his knocking over the sound of the horror movie playing through his earphones. In fact, he thought the furious knocks were coming *from inside* the movie!

Since then, Mydei has never let him live it down, referring to him as the name of the movie he had been watching.

“Deliverer, stop shining your desk lamp at my side of the room, I’m trying to sleep!”

It’s not his fault that Mydei keeps the schedule of an old man, going to sleep by 10PM and getting up at the ass crack of dawn to start his day. Phainon has to work in the darkness, so they’re both making some sacrifices here!

“You idiot! You almost burnt the entire dorm down! If you ever step into the kitchen again, I’ll personally rip out your spine!”

Okay, that was way too cruel of him. But then again, Phainon had woken the entire dorm up at 3am with the fire alarm when he decided he wanted to cook a midnight snack. Mydei, who tended to sleep shirtless, had to deal with shivering in the cold night wind while they waited for the fire department to give them the all clear.

If Phainon drapes his jacket to cover Mydei's shirtless torso it was because he felt guilty and definitely not because of the thinly veiled lustful glances his roommate was receiving from the other students.

"Cyreneeee…. He's the worst." He whines to his best friend over the phone. Cyrene was three years older than him and when she left Aedes Elysia to travel the world, it gave him inspiration to move out as well.

He missed her, she was like an older sister to him, but luckily they still kept in touch over the phone.

All that goodwill evaporates when Cyrene giggles at him, she giggles! Is there anybody who feels sorry for poor Phainon's predicament?

"I don't think he sounds that bad. You told me that since he banned you from entering the kitchen, he's started making your meals."

"But he's been making them bad on purpose! I swear he 'accidentally' burnt my toast this morning but his? Perfectly crisp and toasted!"

"Aww! He sounds really cute!"

"Whose side are you on?" Phainon squawks indignantly, sitting up in his bed. He runs a hand through his hair, sighing. "He's the first person I can't seem to make like me, no matter what I do. In fact, the harder I try the more it seems to piss him off."

In Aedes Elysia, he was the golden boy without even trying. Now in Okhema Phainon is extremely well-liked, becoming friends with most of his coursemates within a week. Even the extremely difficult professors were starting to warm up to him. Truly, there was nobody who made Phainon feel as inadequate as Mydei, and he didn't even have to do anything but exist.

What did he have to do to make Mydei like him?

“Why does he have to like you?” Cyrene asks, delivering armour piercing questions as casually as commenting on the weather. “You’ve been disliked by people before Phainon, it’s no big deal.”

Phainon is stunned into speechlessness, truth be told, he doesn’t even know why he’s so desperate for Mydei’s approval. Phainon was so used to being adored, so used to getting everything he wanted that he couldn’t accept having to work for someone’s approval, especially from someone whom he considered an equal.

“I mean we are roommates, after all, it’s good to get along,” he says with a weak laugh, which probably sounded unconvincing to Cyrene.

“Right, *roommates* .” He did not like Cyrene’s tone when she said that. “But to me, it doesn’t sound like he dislikes you at all. I wouldn’t bother nagging or making food for someone I didn’t like. Perhaps you two just need to talk it out, have a conversation.”

Phainon can only imagine how disastrous a conversation between them would go. He still can’t seem to talk to Mydei without putting his entire foot in his mouth.

Yet it’s weird, there’s something about Mydei that just draws Phainon to him, he can’t stay away.

Phainon’s gym time is one of the most treasured parts of his day. He tends to have a little too much energy at the end of a busy day and the gym is a great place to wind down until he’s too tired to overthink.

While he knows his roommate frequents the gym as well—there’s no way he could get an absurd body like that without training like crazy—their gym schedules are rarely aligned. Mydei wakes up bright and early to train before he starts his day, while Phainon tends to go in the evening and stay until he is tired.

“Oh.” Phainon says as he meets Mydei in the gym, hogging the weightlifting bench. “When you’re done can I use the bench?”

Mydei nods “I’ll be done soon,”

Phainon takes a seat next to him and watches as Mydei finishes his reps. Despite being some of the heaviest plates the gym has to offer, he’s lifting them with perfect form as though they’re weightless. If not for the bulging of his muscles and the sweat dripping down his forehead, one could think that Mydei was hardly putting in any effort at all.

“370.” Phainon says suddenly.

Mydei looks at him like he’s grown an extra head.

“What?” He asks flatly, wiping off with a gym towel. Phainon tries hard not to stare at the trail of sweat dripping past his tank top and rolling onto his tattoos.

“That’s my record, 370 lbs.” It’s a number that Phainon’s very proud of, not to brag, but he can outlift most professional athletes.

He waits for Mydei’s response, maybe to scoff and call his bluff, in which case Phainon gets to show off his impressive strength, or his jaw might drop in surprise, that’ll be fun to see.

Instead, Mydei’s lip curls up in a cat-like smirk, it’s the first time he sees him looking almost… playful and Phainon is starstruck by the sight.

“You’ll need to try harder than that, Deliverer,” Mydei says, patting the weight plates he was lifting earlier. Phainon counts and sure enough, it’s 380 lbs. It broke Phainon’s record weight and Mydei was lifting it with almost no effort.

It is Phainon’s own jaw that drops open. “You sure you’re not like, some kind of demigod or something?”

“Hmph,” Mydei snorts, but his expression is still faintly amused. “...Deadlift?”

Phainon perks up like a puppy, his white hair falling into his eyes from the speed at which he lifts his head. This is the first time Mydei has tried to initiate a conversation with him that isn't about chores. "550."

"Not bad, mine's 540."

"Well, my thighs are pretty strong." Phainon brags.

"Yeah, that's obvious." Mydei agrees readily and Phainon has to do another double take. Mydei is looking at his thighs visible underneath his shorts, and Phainon feels terribly shy about that all of a sudden even though there's nothing but polite curiosity in that glance.

"..100 meter sprint time?"

"10.9 seconds."

"10.8 seconds."

Mydei scowls, the idea of falling behind in 2 out of 3 of their self-inflicted competitions clearly displeasing him. "Continuous pull-ups?"

"21."

Mydei leans back smugly. "26."

What a blow to his ego, yet Phainon finds himself smiling as he shoots back. "Boxing?"

Mydei hums, those golden eyes roving up and down, as though assessing Phainon's capabilities. "I could take you in a fight."

Okay, why did that sound kind of hot? Phainon chooses not to dwell on that thought for a moment and instead airily retorts. "Uh-huh, but can you win? I was the district level boxing champion three years in a row for Amphoreus' youth 16-18 division."

"Fight me yourself and we'll see who comes up on top." Has this guy ever heard of innuendos? Or is he riling up Phainon on purpose.

“Is that a challenge?”

“Only if you’re a match for me.”

Just then, a feral grin splits Mydei’s face, Phainon knows he is wearing a similar expression. It had been a while since Phainon felt so hot-blooded and well… eager. He had always been competitive, but there was never anyone who could be his match in Aedes Elysia and its surrounding townships that things were starting to get boring.

Perhaps Cyrene was partially correct, fighting it out did seem to be more their style.

They fought for 10 rounds, or at least it should be 10, Phainon lost count at around round 5. Most of the rounds ended in a tie, while in others Mydei or Phainon had eked out narrow victories by the skin of their teeth.

“A-another round!” Mydei gritted his teeth, there’s a blossoming bruise on his collarbone where Phainon had accidentally headbutted him, and part of his hair is standing upright from when Phainon pulled on it. It was a dirty trick… but he had been desperate, alright?

“Ha! Are you sure? You look… you look like you can barely stand.” Phainon can’t even get through his sentence without wheezing, he leans against the side of the boxing ring, legs feeling like jelly. Truthfully, Phainon doesn’t know if he can endure another round, but Mydei looks close to his limit as well. It’s only a matter of time before one of them falls over, and it’s damn sure not going to be Phainon because he refuses to lose to this guy.

The lights snap off.

“Are there still students here?” An annoyed voice calls out with the beam of a flashlight. “Get out of here, the gym closed an hour ago!”

With a jolt, both of them realized it was already dark outside, and had been for some time.

The night guard chases them out into the cold night air, still in their gym clothes, before he locks up for the night. Muttering something about ‘stupid college kids’.

“I guess we should end it here for the day…” Mydei finally says quietly, and Phainon chuckles despite himself.

“So, it’s my victory right?” Phainon tries to say cheekily, his legs giving out on him as he slumps down to the ground. Oh, his muscles are going to be sore tomorrow and he deserves every bit of it.

“In your dreams,” Mydei snaps. “I obviously won more rounds.” Still, he extends his hand to Phainon as he sits, sprawled out on the floor. “But you’re strong.”

Phainon just stares up at Mydei in awe as he allows his roommate to help him out. Although he was no doubt as exhausted as Phainon is, he still carried himself strong, shoulders upright, back straight, grip firm. And that look on his face, it’s like he’s seeing Phainon as who he really is, not as the superstar law student, the heartthrob of the campus, the pride of Aedes Elysia, but as a worthy opponent, someone who was his equal.

It is a gaze so piercing that Phainon almost wants to look away, but doesn’t.

“I guess we should just call it a tie, then.”

“Hmph, I’ll win next time.”

Phainon’s heart flutters at the idea that there will be a next time.

“By the way, why were you at the gym so late? Don’t you usually go in the morning?”

Mydei looks away shiftily. “Had a rough day,” he grunts.

Phainon tilts his head to the side. “Is it still a bad day?”

Mydei’s expression shifts, just the smallest of smiles on his lips. “No.”

Mydei’s love language was apparently competition, because something had changed between himself and Mydei. Someone who had started off as just his roommate, soon became a rival and within a few weeks had integrated his position in Phainon’s life as one of his closest friends and confidantes. Mydei had a refreshing personality, one who didn’t care what others thought of him, didn’t mince words, and yet he held a quiet dignity, was willing to stick up for his beliefs, and apologized when he was wrong.

Compared to Phainon, who sometimes felt like he had to wear a mask in order to be accepted and liked by others, they felt like night and day. But to Phainon, it was like Mydei held all the virtues he seeked to embody.

Aglaea

See you at the baths

Hello Mydeimos

Lady Aglaea?

Is something wrong? Did something happen to Phainon??

No, Phainon is fine. My apologies for texting you without context

It's nothing serious, I was simply hoping to ask you for a favour.

Oh, thank the gods. I was worried to suddenly receive a text from Phainon's godmother out of the blue.

What's the favour?

Phainon has requested that I accompany him clothes shopping this weekend.

Unfortunately something has come up and I am unable to make it to our arrangement.

To avoid disappointing him, I would like you to come in my place.

Me?

Clothes shopping???

I was surprised too.

It seems like he wanted to 'change up his image'. Perhaps he's trying to impress somebody. Do you know who?

No.

Why ask me? Why not just reschedule?

I have only met you a few times, but you have a good eye for style and fashion.

Besides, I think Phainon would appreciate your input more than mine.

? Are you serious?

Wonderful, I'll take that as a yes. I'll send you the calendar details.

Oh, and here's some spending money for you.

[Aglaea has transferred 50,000 credits]

...Lady Aglaea this is way too much.

I'm sending it back.

[You are unable to transfer to this number as the recipient has blocked incoming transfers]

Nonsense, I'll have to insist.

Please, accept it as compensation for dealing with him.

When Phainon asked Aglaea to help him pick out some new clothes, he had not expected Mydei of all people to show up.

“Fancy seeing you here!” Phainon grins, of course, he’s always happy to see Mydei, especially when it’s unplanned. “Are you here for shopping too?”

Mydei’s expression sours. “Did Aglaea not tell you I was coming in her place?”

Phainon’s smile tightens, yeah, he had a feeling that this was a setup. Aglaea needs to stop setting up playdates with Mydei for him… he’s perfectly capable of disturbing Mydei himself.

He takes his phone out of his pocket to see that yes, she had sent him a message informing him of the switch, a mere five minutes ago.

“Ah… I just saw the message.”

His trepidation must have shown, because the angle of Mydei’s eyebrows lowers ever so slightly. He may appear stoic to others, but Phainon has learned to read the microexpressions on his face.

Any moment now, he’s going to suggest they abandon this pursuit.

“Maybe it’s better if we wait until Aglaea is free.”

Called it. Read him like a book.

“Wait a second!” Phainon steps forward, grabbing Mydei’s sleeve to stop him walking away. “I never said I had a problem with this arrangement. You have a great sense of style, I always thought so.” Like today, he clearly dressed to kill, a fitted loose red shirt tucked into black ripped jeans, a pair of shades balanced on his head while his hair was done in a half-ponytail.

“Then why didn’t you just ask me to come with you directly?” Mydei doesn’t pout, but this is the closest Phainon will get to it. He can be surprisingly cute for a 6’2 man in combat boots.

Phainon scratches the back of his neck. “Geez, at least allow a guy to keep his dignity.”

Mydei just scoffs. “Bold of you to say that when I’ve already seen you drool in your sleep.”

Phainon pouts, lowering his head and putting forward his best puppy dog eyes. Mydei raises an eyebrow at him, before his gaze slowly strays down to the clothes he’s wearing today, frown deepening all the while.

“What’s wrong?” Phainon thought he was meeting Aglaea, so he thought he’d try to pick clothes that were a little nicer today so she wouldn’t try to strip him in public.

“Your outfit…” Mydei says in a voice that sounds physically pained.

Phainon straightens his body and gestures down to himself. “What do you think?” A blue short-sleeved button-up the colour of the sky, matching with yellow plaid trousers the colour of the sun. This combination reminds him of a sunny field in Aedes Elysia, and certainly suits his bright and cheerful demeanor.

Mydei’s expression twists into one that cannot be described with mere words.

“Are you wearing an undershirt?” He asks suddenly.

“Yes?”

“Colour?”

“White?”

Without any warning Mydei’s hands are all over him, undoing his buttons with terrifying efficiency.

“At least buy me dinner first!” Phainon yelps as he practically rips the front of his shirt open.

Oops, Phainon remembered wrongly, his undershirt wasn’t white, it was bright orange.

Look, it’s not like he was expecting Mydei to partially undress him today! It wasn’t meant to be seen.

Phainon watches as Mydei goes through the five stages of grief right in front of him.

“Nikador strike me down, Lady Aglaea’s task is more formidable than I thought,” Mydei sighs, turning around and walking straight towards the direction of the clothing stores.

“Since when are you in touch with Aglaea anyway?” Phainon jogs a little to keep up with Mydei’s brisk pace, his jaw is set, eyebrows taut, with all the gravitas of a general going to war.

“We exchanged numbers after the last time you ended up in hospital. She thought it would be a good idea to keep in touch just in case you ended up falling off the balcony or something.”

“I twisted my ankle on the stairs, once! And you two never let me live it down! So you just said yes when she asked you to take me clothes shopping? Wow, you must really like me.” If Phainon had a tail, it would be wagging right now with how pleased he is.

“Shut up, Deliverer.” He says that final part with such venom that it’s almost like he’s spitting poison. But Phainon knows he doesn’t mean it. Besides, his words don’t match his actions, for Mydei is marching up and down the racks of clothes, picking out ones he deems suitable.

“Here, a few items that would suit your hair colour and skin tone, which one do you like?” He says, dumping them into his arms.

“Huh?” Phainon tilts his head to the side. “Isn’t that why you’re here, to choose for me? Aglaea wouldn’t let me pick anything of my own.”

“It’s important that you feel comfortable in whatever clothes you choose, I can’t make those decisions for you.”

“Then…” Phainon trails after Mydei, still holding the piles of clothes in his hands. “I think I’d feel most comfortable in whatever you find attractive on me.”

Mydei’s face twists as he tries to process Phainon’s convoluted logic. But to Phainon, the answer is glaringly simple. Mydei has good taste, so whatever he finds attractive should work on other people as well.

“Ugh… this juvenile… Deliverer, rather than what I like, you should think about what kind of person you like.”

He stops, staring at Phainon expectantly.

Phainon feels put on the spot, he hasn’t given much thought as to what kind of person he would like. He’s a bit of a social chameleon, always molding himself into whatever the people around him need. A model student, an obedient son, a fun-loving fraternity brother.

Sometimes it feels like Mydei is the only person that sees Phainon for who he really is, imperfect, flawed, but still an equal.

“Someone like you, maybe?”

Mydei’s jaw drops. “What?”

Phainon’s mouth moves faster than his brain. “But not you, of course, please don’t rip my spine out.”

Mydei’s jaw shifts from left to right, like he’s gritting his teeth. Phainon is not sure which part of what he said offended him, but he knows he’s really put his foot in his mouth this time.

“Hmph.” That’s not even a word, that’s just a grunt!

Adding to that would likely make things worse, so Phainon wisely decides to keep silent for now. Who wouldn’t be uncomfortable at the idea that their friend, an ex-roommate, a comrade and confidante, would be attracted to them? It’s true that Mydei is his ideal type, but he won’t fall in love with

him, can’t fall in love with him, their friendship means everything to Phainon.

So that’s why he’s doing this, if he can find someone half as good as Mydei, that would be good enough for him.

Mydei hardly gets to walk ahead a few paces before he’s stopped.

“Mydei?” Phainon asks in a small voice, trailing after him still holding the pile of clothes in his arms. “You’re not mad at me are you?”

A fully grown, 6’2 man whining after another fully grown man in a clothing store must be quite the sight. Mydei sighs, his back expanding with the effort of his exhale, before he turns around, crossing his arms. His expression is carefully neutral, and Phainon fails to read his thoughts behind even the slightest twitch on an eyebrow.

“No,” He gestures to the clothes in Phainon’s arms. “I was taking you to try these on. I need to see how they look on you before making any evaluations.”

“Oh,” Phainon says, relief flooding through his veins. For a moment he had wanted to die, he really thought he fucked this up. Thank goodness Mydei didn’t think much of it.

Whilst Mydei hadn’t treated him any differently afterwards, Phainon did feel a shift in his behaviour. Mydei was more closed off, poker-faced in situations where had been more likely to smile. Phainon can’t even gauge which one of the outfits he liked the most, as he remained stoic throughout the entire fitting room session.

Ultimately, it was a successful shopping expedition as Phainon returned home with several bags full of Mydei-approved clothing, sponsored by Aglaea. When he unpacks, he finds a jewelry box among them that he distinctly remembers not paying for.

Inside is a choker, dark brown, leather, smooth and soft to the touch. Phainon doesn’t remember buying this, but he does remember seeing it in

one of the stores. He had left it then, since he wasn’t exactly an accessories guy.

But Mydei was, golden necklaces passed down from his mother, dangling earrings with blue gems that sparkle in the light, bracelets that hug his muscular forearms sinfully. He wore accessories in most of his outfits, and looked great doing it.

Mydei

30% Training, 70% Diet

Mydei, I found a choker in my purchases

Did you buy this for me?

Yes



Wasn't this expensive?!?

How much is it? I'll pay you back.

No need. I think it would look good on you.

Aglaea gave me some money anyway. It's only right that it's spent on you.

Mydei had already said that it was purchased with money Aglaea gave him, but why was Phainon blushing like he had received a gift from his crush?

He removes the choker from the box, the leather is sturdy, not likely to break even if stress was applied. When he puts it on, it fits snugly around his neck. Tight enough to stay in place, but still loose enough to slip two fingers in.

Phainon inspects himself in the mirror, turning his head from side to side. The collar stands out against his pale skin and white hair, and somehow draws even more attention to the sun tattoo on his neck.

“Huh,” Phainon says, rather impressed with what he saw. “Not bad.”

Switching up his fashion style was such a small change in the grand scheme of things, but its impact couldn’t be denied. Some people he had never met before in college have come up to ask for his number. A couple of girls in his course have asked him to tutor them even though their exams had already passed. The cashier at the convenience store gave him a really obvious once over and then peeks at the name on his credit card.

As expected, any advice from Mydei is really good advice.

Despite this, Phainon still isn’t closer to finding the college romance he so longed for, and worst of all, there was a conspicuous absence of Mydei from his life.

He had expected for them to see each other less once they moved out from the dorms, but it didn’t stop him from still wanting a friendship with Mydei. Most of the time, it worked, coordinating their gym sessions, going out for meals, studying in the library together, accidentally ‘bumping into each other’ in campus, there were still plenty of opportunities for them to see each other.

Phainon just hadn’t realized how many of those opportunities stemmed from Mydei’s efforts to meet him in the middle.

Lately, whenever he tried to text Mydei to hang out, he always got the same answer. Busy, got something else to do, already went to the gym this morning. Charming the girls from the history course gave him no answers, Mydei was attending classes as usual, nothing seemed out of the ordinary except for the fact that he was avoiding Phainon.

Did he do something that day to offend him? Aside from accidentally confessing that Mydei was his type. Mydei hadn’t seemed to take any mind though, and even gifted him jewelry! Should Phainon text him to apologize about it? Or would Mydei think he was stupid for bringing up something so insignificant! Argh! Would Mydei find it pathetic that he can’t stop overthinking this?

It’s been three weeks since he last saw Mydei, and Phainon feels like he’s melting into a glob, even his hair is wilting. It’s not like he doesn’t have other friends he can hang out with, so why is he so strung up over this? Phainon didn’t understand it himself.

He was the one who bought Phainon his choker, didn’t he want to see it for himself?

When he finally, *finally* , receives a text from Mydei after what seems like forever, Phainon can’t stop the cold sweat that breaks out from his relief.

Mydei

30% Training, 70% Diet

Deliverer, are you free this weekend?

For you, I'm always free!

...right

Do you want to come to my place for dinner? There's someone I want you to meet.

A friend from Kremnos

Phainon frowns at his phone as he texts his affirmation, he feels both overjoyed, yet strangely apprehensive at the same time. Mydei avoids him for weeks, then suddenly has a ‘friend’ to introduce him to? What was that all about?

Mydei

30% Training, 70% Diet

Who is your friend?

You'll meet him when you get here.

So it’s a he. A vague, unsettling and ominous anwer. But this was a good opportunity to learn more about Mydei’s life in Kremnos, for he didn’t share that part of himself often. Besides, he really, really missed Mydei’s home-cooked meals.

Since Mydei wanted him to meet someone, Phainon figured he’d make a good impression. Besides, he really wants Mydei to see the new and improved him. So, he dresses up in his nicest clothes, nothing too flashy, he didn’t want to embarrass him. Just a loose white shirt that he leaves unbuttoned enough to show his clavicles, tucked loosely into black jeans. Puts a little bit of wax in his hair so that it’s pushed back neatly on one side and fluffy on the other. And of course, he can’t forget the choker Mydei gave him, it’s been a mainstay in his daily wear ever since he got it.

Mydei lives in a nice apartment just down the street from their favourite gym, Phainon knows he’s got some money from his father. Reparations for a shitty childhood, Mydei had said once without elaborating. Still, it’s a cozy place, Phainon would love to live here instead of his noisy, smelly fraternity house.

Even if being around Mydei 24/7 would be bad for his heart.

Mydei stares at him a little longer than usual when he opens the door. Phainon almost preens when those golden eyes drift down to the choker around his neck. Mydei's eyes are like laser beams, burning his body as they rove over him. And right then and there, he thinks he sees Mydei swallow.

Was that the good kind of swallow? The 'yikes!' kind of swallow? Or was it a trick of the light? Phainon doesn't know how to make heads or tails of it.

"Do… do I look okay?" He asks, hesitantly.

"You look nice." Mydei simply states as a greeting.

"Thanks!" Phainon says, inwardly sighing in relief. "You look nice too!" Mydei looks nice even when he's sleep deprived at 4am working on a reading assignment, it's the benefit of having perfect genes. But wow, he really missed seeing Mydei relaxed, wearing just a loose t-shirt and track pants, with his gold-rimmed glasses that he only wears at home.

"Come in." Mydei says, opening the door wider for him. "I told you I had a friend from Kremnos over, I'd like you to meet him."

"Of course! You hardly talk about your time in Kremnos, so I'm excited," Phainon says cheerfully, stepping in. Truthfully, Phainon is dreading this. He's got a sinking feeling that this 'friend' might be the reason why he hasn't gotten the opportunity to see Mydei at all, lately.

"Phainon, this is Hephaestion." And Phainon is so distracted by the rare opportunity to hear Mydei call him by name that he almost forgets to shake the slender, pale hand that is offered to him.

"Nice to finally meet you, his highness speaks a lot about you."

"His highness?" Phainon's heart lurches again, and unpleasant heaviness fills his chest at the idea that Mydei allows Hephaestion to call him by a nickname while Phainon just calls him the same as everyone else.

“Oh, it’s just a nickname we used to call him in high school. It sort of stuck.” Phainon looks to Mydei, looking to catch a flicker of disapproval, of annoyance, anything. Instead, Mydei rolls his eyes in a way that is almost fond and says nothing.

Phainon laughs, hoping it doesn’t sound too fake. “And how long have you known Mydei?”

“We’ve known each other since grade school, isn’t that right?” Hephaestion puts his arm around Mydei’s shoulder and he just *lets* him. Phainon had taken pride in being the only one allowed to do so, and even then Mydei would normally grumble and complain or… something.

“Hephaestion is pursuing his studies in anthropology, and is in town this week on a study trip curating artifacts at the museum. Given your… hobbies in antiques, I thought you might get along.”

“It is very nice to meet you,” Phainon says, forcing his smile. “It’s surprising that Mydei hasn’t mentioned you to me.”

“ *HKS* ! What’s gotten into you!” Mydei says, outraged. He turns to Hephaestion hastily. “He does not mean offence. He sometimes speaks first without thinking.”

“No worries, I think it’s cute.” Hephaestion winks at him, and Phainon is sure that man is making fun of him now.

Mydei is quiet for a moment, silently evaluating, before he sighs, appeased by the answer. “Alright, we can catch up over dinner. Come, the food is ready.”

Phainon grits his teeth, he hates everything about this. Here’s someone from Mydei’s life that he is apparently very close to, close enough to walk around in Mydei’s home like he owns the goddamn place. Knowing that Mydei is normally rather reserved, it stings doubly so. If they were still roommates… if Phainon had just bit the bullet and asked Mydei if he wanted to continue to live together, maybe he wouldn’t be left in the dust like this.

Hephaestion is beautiful, tall and slender in places where Phainon is not, long flowing pink hair that's so pale it looks almost white in the light, soft gray eyes that are slightly upturned at the ends, long lashes fanning his cheeks. He's pretty in the ways Phainon cannot be, delicate curves where Phainon is hard muscle.

He wonders if this is the type of man Mydei prefers, soft and pretty and gentle. Mydei is his type, but he had never stopped to wonder if he's Mydei's type at all.

The realization upsets him more than he ever thought possible.

Mydei's cooking is as delicious as he remembers it, it feels like a sin not to enjoy it. But Phainon can't stop stealing glances at Hephaestion and wondering what qualities he has that Phainon doesn't have. He can't do anything about a shared childhood, or about their vastly different appearances, but is it that he's soft-spoken? Phainon could do that, he could talk less. Or is it that he has the 'tortured artist' vibe going on, because he could do that too!

"Are you alright, Phainon, you look… unwell." Hephaestion says, concern lacing his tone.

Phainon is acutely aware that everyone at the table is now looking at him. There is a wrinkle marring Mydei's perfect features that indicates he's worried. Great, now Phainon is ruining dinner too.

"No, I'm fine. Dinner is fantastic as usual, De." Hephaestion isn't the only person who gets to call him by a nickname! Phainon can do so too.

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "...De?"

Ugh… nevermind, this isn't really working. "Do you not like it?"

"...I think it's a bit too cute for me."

Hephaestion just laughs, it's a light, delicate sound like the tinkling of windchimes. Phainon immediately hates it as well, so different from his

own, loud and boisterous. “I think it suits you, you’re pretty cute after all, ‘De’.”

Phainon hopes his killing intent doesn’t come across too strongly, because now he’s trying to steal the nickname that he came up with too! And he just called Mydei cute without batting an eye, Phainon has been trying to do that for *years* !

“Uh-huh, I’m glad you two are finding common ground.” Mydei replies, though he doesn’t have a rebuttal to being called cute.

Dinner carries on as normal, though admittedly Hephaestion is doing most of the heavy lifting when it comes to making conversation. Phainon manages to hide his feelings enough to appear normal, though sometimes Mydei would give him a questioning look, like he’s noticed something.

“What do you think of Hephaestion?” Mydei asks casually as he does the dishes. They had gotten into the habit of it as roommates. Mydei cooks, Phainon helps with the cleaning. But because he doesn’t live here (and there’s the lurching feeling in his chest again, feeling like indigestion), he has no idea where anything is kept, so Mydei is drying and putting them away.

“He’s nice,” Phainon says. “I like him.” He lies clenching his teeth. Hephaestion is nice, he’s witty, intelligent, and thoughtfully funny too. Under normal circumstances, Phainon would like him. But he doesn’t. He hates him.

Hates that Hephaestion shares inside jokes and memories with Mydei that he never will, hates that Mydei just allows him to tease him, hates that Hephaestion keeps looking at him with a sly smile that seems to indicate he knows something that Phainon doesn’t.

“If you want his number let me know. I’m sure he won’t mind.”

“I’ll keep that in mind.” It took five weeks, five weeks of living together to get Mydei’s number, it felt like Phainon had won the holy grail. He *earned*

that phone number, and meanwhile here's Mydei giving away someone else's phone number so easily.

"It's still early, why don't you stay and watch a movie with us?" So Mydei was just planning to watch a movie with Hephaestion now, too? That used to be *their* thing! This day is just getting worse and worse.

"Sure." Phainon smiles, at least he can be there to intercept it this time.

Mydei nods. "I'll prepare some snacks, you can go find Hephaestion in the living room, he's picking movies."

He finds Hephaestion making himself at home on Mydei's couch.

"Oh hey!" He says, turning back to look at him. "Any preferences on movies? I'm thinking horror. Oh, and you don't mind if I take the couch, do you? I have a bad back."

Mydei's couch is a bit on the smaller size, more than enough for one person, but a bit of a tight squeeze for two adult men. Two men of Mydei and Phainon's size sitting next to each other on it would have their shoulder's brushing, Phainon knows, he tested it out himself.

If Hephaestion is using the excuse of a horror movie to cuddle up to Mydei, then…

"What a coincidence, I twisted my muscle in the gym today too, so I'll prefer the couch as well." Phainon smiles, taking up the available spot next to him.

And it's back, that knowing look that Phainon is really starting to despise. The one that indicates that Hephaestion knows something he doesn't. "Oh? I'm sure his highness won't mind."

There it is again, that goddamned nickname. Overcome by the need to prove himself, Phainon leans forward so there's only inches separating himself from Hephaestion and he says. "Mydei calls me 'Deliverer'." But prove himself of what? Phainon isn't sure himself.

Instead of deterring him, Hephaestion's smile widens. "Deliverer." Shivers runs down Phainon's spine, he hates it being called with another person's voice, only Mydei has the right to call him Deliverer. "Mydei hasn't mentioned that at all. Interesting."

"What are you two whispering about?" A grumpy voice from behind them. Phainon immediately pulls away from Hephaestion, aiming his sunniest smile at Mydei. He is going to take that as a win, if even his dear childhood friend Hephaestion doesn't even have a cute nickname. Two nicknames, actually, counting *HKS* .

Mydei sees both of them sitting on the couch, with no room for a third person, and sighs. "In my own home," he says, deadpan.

"You can come sit on our lap, Mydei. I'm sure Phainon wouldn't mind."

"No thanks, I was just joking." Of course he wouldn't do it, Phainon sighs as Mydei moves to take a seat on the floor in front of the couch.

Phainon knows Mydei isn't afraid of horror movies, and true to form he doesn't even flinch through the loudest jump scares or the goriest kills. Phainon himself is hardly paying attention to the movie, he wouldn't be able to tell you who the main characters are.

Phainon had never considered himself a possessive guy, he was always like a big brother to the children of Aedes Elysia, cheerful, reliable, and more than happy to share. But when it comes to Mydei, he doesn't want to share Mydei.

He can no longer deny the fact that he's jealous. Jealous that Mydei had other friends he was close to, other friends whom he allowed to use nicknames, friends that could come and go to his home freely. He feared that the 3 weeks of not speaking to Mydei will become 3 months, then 3 years, then forever. He dreads Mydei being stolen away from him by someone with Hephaestion's face.

Mydei is just sitting in front of him, with his broad back on display. The red tattoos snake up from his skin, visible through his thin t-shirt, vivid against

the light from the television. Phainon can't help but reach out his hand, brushing his fingers against the slant of his shoulder, feeling the muscle twitch and tense under his touch.

"Hephaestion," Mydei grumbles without even looking back, reaching a hand to flick him away like he's swatting a fly. "I told you your cheap scare tactics don't work on me, get your cold ass hands off me."

"What? I didn't even do anything," Hephaestion replies defensively, to which Mydei turns around to growl at him.

Not at Phainon, at Hephaestion. The ugly, resentful feeling in Phainon's heart continues to grow.

He keeps his hands to himself until the end of the movie, are his hands really that cold? Phainon usually ran hot. Ruminating on what has happened until the credits start to roll.

Mydei has his head in a weird position, neck twisted almost horizontally on the arm rest. He doesn't shift when Phainon moves to inspect. His eyes are closed peacefully, blonde bangs swept away revealing his forehead, with his breathing even and relaxed. Mydei had fallen asleep.

Phainon can only stare in awe at how beautiful he looks when his face is completely relaxed like this, how vulnerable. With soft pink lips parted slightly as he inhales and exhales, if he really wanted to, Phainon could almost close the distance between them and… kiss him.

Why… why did he suddenly really want to kiss Mydei? He hadn't really thought about it at all, until today.

A soft cough draws Phainon's attention, reminding him he's not alone here. Phainon quickly draws his head back to look at Hephaestion, who wears a fond smile on his face as he looks down at the sleeping Mydei.

"Can never stay awake during a movie, same old Mydeimos." He says, and Phainon hates the gentleness in his voice, hates that he's looking at Mydei with the same expression of fondness that Phainon undoubtedly shares.

The sound of his voice is like the breaking of a spell, and it's not long before Mydei's eyes flutter open, gold irises blinking through the sleepy haze as Mydei comes back to life.

"Huh… it's over?" He murmurs, propping himself upright and running a hand through his hair. It had become messy due to the awkward sleeping position, frayed at the ends with stray hairs sticking out all over the place, looking very much like a lion's mane.

"Mydei, your braid has come undone, let me help you with that." Phainon says, reaching out to braid the loose strands back into place. Mydei backs away so quickly that his head nearly slams into the armrest of the couch.

"Thanks, but I got it." Mydei says. Fully awake now, he stands up and makes a beeline in the direction of the bathroom, leaving Phainon gaping in his wake.

The hurt must have seemed pretty obvious on his face, because Hephaestion takes the chance to comfort him. "Don't take offense," he says. "Hair is sacred to a Kremnoan, and Mydei despite what he seems, is a pretty traditional guy. In Kremnoan culture, only family members can touch the hair, or someone very close, like a significant other."

Phainon turns around slowly to face Hephaestion, and finally asks the question that is on his mind. "Does he let you touch his hair?"

"Oh," Hephaestion says, the corner of his eyes crinkling into a smile. "How forward, are you jealous?"

He's toying with Phainon, not answering the question on purpose. Phainon scowls at him, all pretense dropped, because the truth is, Mydei *has* allowed him to touch his hair before, even before Phainon knew what Kremnoan traditions were.

It was towards the end of their 1st year, as their lease in the student dorms was coming to an end. Phainon and Mydei had taken to the habit of

working on their assignments together in their dorm room. Something about competing with each other over who can finish their work the fastest did wonders for their productivity. Often, it was more effective than pulling all nighters in the library.

“Just so you know,” Phainon says, leaning over his shoulder to speak to Mydei as they’re sitting back to back, books and folders strewn all around them on the floor. “I’m on my closing paragraph.”

“Then you’re too slow, Deliverer.” Mydei murmurs back, his voice low and relaxed like a bubbling creek. “I’m already compiling the bibliography.”

“We’ll see about that, I’ve been known to swoop in and steal the win at the last minute.” Phainon teases back, his voice almost a whisper.

“Can’t hear you over the sound of me winning this competition.” Mydei murmurs, his voice almost lost among the sound of typing.

Phainon locks into his own work as well, if only to rub his win into Mydei’s face later.

A few minutes later, or it might have been 15, 30, maybe an hour. Phainon and Mydei finally end their furious typing with a cry of “Done! It’s my win!” in unison.

It took less than a second for the argument to begin.

“I called it a second before you did.”

“That’s where you’re wrong, my dear Mydeimos. I actually declared my victory after the submission had gone through, while you were just clicking yours.”

“ *HKS* ! I will not fall for your dirty tricks.”

Phainon’s eyebrows straighten, his gleeful smirk turning into childlike curiosity. “You keep calling me that word, lately. Haikas? Haiks? What does that mean?”

“ *HKS* .” Mydei repeats again, tongue rolling with a pronunciation that Phainon struggles with. “It’s Kremnoan, means hyena.”

“Hyena?” Phainon says, making a face. “Surely if you wanted to give me a cute nickname you could have chosen better animals.”

“Only a *HKS* would hear this and think I’m calling him cute.” Mydei says with no venom.

“How about a butterfly?” Phainon suggests, completely ignoring the jibe.

“There is no word in the Kremnoan’s dictionary for butterfly.”

“Rabbit? Oh, how about a puppy!”

“The closest word we have in Kremnoan to a dog is hyena. *HKS* .”

“Oh,” Phainon pouts. “It would seem that the Kremnoan dictionary doesn’t have a lot of words.”

“Yes.” Mydei says dryly. “All the Kremnoan libraries were burned down in the Chrysos War, leaving us very few records of the language. With Castrum Kremnos being a nation of war, I don’t think archiving their dictionaries became the highest priority. I’m afraid a lot of Kremnoan vocabulary has been lost to time.”

“That’s a shame,” Phainon says, resting his chin on Mydei’s shoulder, peeking at his laptop screen. “It sounds a little crude, but I think it’s a very beautiful language.” Or perhaps anything spoken in Mydei’s deep, guttural voice would sound beautiful to Phainon’s ears.

“A forgotten language, one that even most native Kremnoans won’t know how to speak.” Mydei huffs.

“Yet here you are, pursuing your degree in history, trying your best to unearth your culture’s traditions and keep it alive. I think it’s very admirable of you, Mydei.”

He feels Mydei become very still, and tilts his head in question, the longer locks of hair framing his face brushing Mydei's shoulder slightly. Some might find their excessive skinship kind of strange, for two friends, but Phainon had always been a tactile person, and Mydei didn't seem to mind, otherwise he would have shoved him off already.

"You don't think it's… a waste?" Mydei says, sounding uncertain. "That I'm pursuing history instead of doing something like… I don't know… taking over my family's successful business."

"You have a family business?" Phainon questions, he had never thought about it too deeply, but Mydei never seemed to have an issue when finances were concerned. His wardrobe, while not extensive, consisted of clothing of high quality from expensive brands. He took care of all their groceries, even Phainon's share without asking him to pay it back. Even his kitchen utensils seem to be expensive. "Mydei… are you… rich?"

Mydei shakes his head no. "I'm… comfortable." Is all he says. "The family business actually belongs to my father."

Phainon is doubly curious now, he knows Mydei is close to his mother, Gorgo. They often video call in the dorm, and Phainon has even said hi to her a few times. She is a lovely lady, and Mydei is a carbon copy of her, looks wise.

"This is the first time you spoke about your father," Phainon says, voice low, as though doing anything to break it will spoil the talkative mood Mydei suddenly finds himself in. "Forgive me if I sound insensitive, but I previously thought you didn't have one."

Mydei just huffs, disdainful and resentful. "I think I would have preferred that."

"Truly?" Phainon asks. Unlike Mydei, Phainon really didn't have an interesting childhood. It was peaceful, loving, normal. Besides, he was always curious when it came to Mydei, he wanted to know everything about him. "Do you want to elaborate on that?"

“No.”

Phainon knows Mydei well enough that it’s his cue to drop the subject. Although he’s still curious, he’s happy to do so since Mydei’s already shared a lot with him today.

“Anyway, Mydei, do you have any plans for living arrangements once the school year ends?” Phainon asks, smoothly changing the subject.

“Not yet, I was thinking of renting an apartment close to campus.”

“Yeah, that sounds like a good idea. Having your own place would be nice.” Phainon says wistfully.

Mydei hesitates, as though thinking something through “...Apartments with two bedrooms are easier to find… and easier to split the bills for.”

“That’s true, whoever your next roommate is, they’re a lucky guy, or girl..”

Surprise flickers on Mydei’s face for just the slightest of moments before it settles into its usual stoic expression. “Oh,” he says, a little flatly. “How about you? What are your living plans for next year?”

“I’m pledging to a fraternity so I can live in their frat house.” Phainon says. “It’ll be cheaper and close to campus as well.”

“That… makes sense, it’ll always be noisy and busy there… it suits you.”

Phainon pouts. “Why do you make me sound like a puppy that can’t be left alone?”

Mydei scoffs at that, the corner of his lip curling up into a smile. “You said it, not me.”

And when he makes that kind of soft expression, he’s so breathtaking that Phainon can’t help but just… stare for a moment.

Mydei notices, the golden irises that almost glow yellow in the cheap desk light lift to stare him in the eye. “What? Something on my face?”

“Your braid,” Phainon says hastily, eyes shifting to the lock of hair behind Mydei’s right ear that is constantly braided. “It’s come loose.”

“Has it?” Mydei tilts his head towards Phainon. “Why don’t you come fix it for me then?”

Phainon swallows, suddenly feeling that his mouth is really dry. Truthfully, he didn’t know how to braid, but the opportunity to touch Mydei’s hair was right there, so how could he resist? Carefully, delicately, he reaches out his hand, slipping his fingers into Mydei’s blonde locks. Titans, his hair is so soft, the way it entangles between his fingers, choppy ends delicately prickling his skin. Slowly, Phainon does his best to braid, following the pattern set by the top half of Mydei’s braid, which is still intact. This lock goes under that strand, which goes over this… right?

Phainon tries to look to Mydei for answers, only to find his eyes closed, expression relaxed. They’re so close that Phainon can see the individual eyelashes fluttering as he breathes.

“Done… if it’s wonky you can’t blame me.” Phainon finally pulls away, face flushed, heart racing from the proximity.

Mydei opens a single golden eye, looking for all the world like a grumpy lion interrupted from its grooming, and opens his front camera to assess his reflection.

“Deliverer… you have no skill in braiding at all.” The braid is crooked, the strands are uneven in diameter, and Phainon had messed up the pattern so one bunch loops around awkwardly.

“Sorry! It’s not like I have any hair to braid!” Phainon says almost offendedly, pointing at his own, much shorter locks. “You can just redo it if you don’t like it.”

Come to think of it, Phainon remembered Mydei leaving the room the next day with the wonky braid still intact. Despite all his complaining, he never actually redid it.

Since that day, Phainon is proud to say that his braiding skill has improved. He practiced more, watched some tutorials, and even found himself unconsciously doing it with his hoodie strings. His braid is indistinguishable from the ones Mydei does himself. Whenever he reaches out to touch Mydei's hair, or runs his fingers through it, Mydei never backs away.

Until today.

A privilege that was previously offered freely to Phainon had a deeper meaning than he could ever have realized.

And now it's no longer his to take.

Phainon's throat squeezes with anxiety, there's a knot in his stomach that doesn't want to come undone.

Phainon is jealous.

He is so jealous that it takes every ounce of his acting skills to act normally as he bids his goodbyes to Mydei and Hephaestion. He is so jealous that on the walk home, his facial expression is so dark that everyone who passes him crosses the street to avoid him. He's so jealous that he tosses and turns in his bed, unable to sleep because of the racing thoughts in his head. He is so jealous that everything he eats turns to sludge in his mouth. He is so jealous that he can't think of anything else aside from Mydei, and whether Mydei and Hephaestion are together, and whether Mydei likes Hephaestion in a romantic way, and what Phainon can do to stop that. He is so jealous that after a few fitful hours of sleep, he wakes up with an embarrassing tent in his pants.

Phainon gives up.

He can no longer deny his attraction to Mydei, the way he has to bite down on his own pillowcase to stop himself from moaning out his name too loudly. He wraps his fingers around his own leaking cock and pretends it's

Mydei. It’s not the same, Mydei’s fingers are a little thicker and shorter than his own, fingertips and palms calloused from guitar practice and lifting weights. But still, Mydei would look good looming over him, muscled arms keeping Phainon pinned to the bed, red tattoos streaking all over his chest, continuing under his boxer shorts. Or maybe, he’d look even better under Phainon, blonde hair splayed across the pillow, cheeks flushed red matching prettily with the tattoo underneath his eye.

“What are you waiting for?” He’d say in a low growl, looking away, because even in Phainon’s imagination Mydei would still be bashful about it. “Put it in.”

Phainon’s pelvis jerks, his thumb presses into the tip of his cock and he comes so hard that he sees stars.

After cleaning himself up, he just lies in bed, feeling really, really pathetic.

Phainon is so jealous that he has to take a sick day, because he is apparently incapable of functioning like a normal human anymore.

He hasn’t taken a sick day since he was a child.

A soft knock comes through his door, it’s not uncommon since he lives in a frat house full of people. Many of them have been concerned about his sudden change in behavior, but Phainon’s not in the mood to keep up the act. He turns around in bed, back facing the entrance.

“Deliverer, I know you’re inside there, open the door!” The roar comes accompanied by a louder knock that makes the door shake on its hinges.

The sound of Mydei’s voice makes Phainon spring up from the bed and run to open the door before he actually knocks it down.

“You should have told me you were sick.” Mydei grumbles, he looks as put together as ever and stands out in the dingy frat house corridor. In his hand he holds a heat-resistant takeout container. “Your frat mates have been panic calling me all morning. If I hear someone call me ‘Mydeimos my

dude’ or ‘Mydeimos my bro’ one more time, I will start punching someone.”

Phainon opens the door wider, jaw dropping open. It is both his sweetest dream and worst nightmare that Mydei is here right now. A part of him, the dark, possessive part that he’s ashamed to show others, is gnashing his teeth in delight that everyone knows Mydei belongs to him. The other side just misses him, yearns to be close again, to go back to what they had before. Yet Phainon still hasn’t managed to process these feelings he has about Mydei. Feelings so intense that it feels like he’s drowning.

“Have you been looking after yourself? I bought you soup, eat.” Mydei steps into his room without being asked, and immediately raises a hand to touch his forehead. Such an innocuous touch, Phainon wouldn’t have thought much of it, but that was before. Now, the sensation of Mydei’s warm hand against his forehead makes heat rise straight to his head.

“ *HKS* ! You’re running a fever. You need rest.” Mydei practically manhandles him to the bed. “What happened to you? You were acting strange at dinner the other day and now you’re sick. You never used to get sick when we were roommates, I thought idiots can’t catch colds.”

Phainon obediently lies down on the bed, still too stunned to speak as Mydei opens his bag and takes out a bowl he’s brought from home and a spoon. He really does think of everything.

“Eat.” He demands again, forcing the bowl into Phainon’s outstretched hands. The warmth of the soup is pleasant against his palms, and the delicious aroma wafts out of the bowl. In a few days he’s already gotten to eat Mydei’s cooking twice, Phainon is so happy he could almost cry, but he forces those tears down.

Meanwhile, Mydei is storming through his room. Picking laundry off the floor, separating it into lights and darks, tossing trash into the bin, putting away stuff that’s been left out. He’s like a hurricane, a monster whose sole intent is to clean.

“Wait!” Phainon says, suddenly incredibly aware that this means Mydei is going to see his trash and the discarded tissues he left there after jacking himself off while thinking of his best friend.

“What? Feeling embarrassed now, Deliverer? Where was this shame back when we were roommates? Now eat.” Mydei’s tone bids no room for argument, so Phainon has no choice but to do as he’s told, hoping and praying that Mydei doesn’t notice anything amiss.

“If I knew you were feeling unwell, I wouldn’t have asked you to come over,” Mydei murmurs under his breath.

“No!” Phainon shakes his head, voice muffled from how full his mouth is. Meeting Mydei’s disapproving gaze he swallows and tries again. “I mean, I’m glad you invited me. I’m happy I got to meet Hephaestion.” But because Phainon is a sick man, lovesick, that is, he can’t help but ask. “Do you like him?”

“Do I like him?” Mydei repeats incredulously. “Do I seem like the kind of person who would stay friends with someone I don’t like?”

“Do you like him,” Phainon repeats, desperate for an answer “romantically? Do you think you would date him?”

That one catches Mydei by surprise, he stands in the middle of Phainon’s room, arms stacked with laundry. “Huh?” He just exclaims intelligently. “If you want me to vouch for his character, I can do so. Hephaestion is one of my closest friends. I wouldn’t introduce him to you if I didn’t think he’d make a good partner.”

They’re in the same room, yet Mydei feels like he’s a million miles away. It feels like they’re circling each other and Phainon just can’t get through to him.

But Mydei is smart, he always has been and his facial expression deepens into a frown as he tries to piece together what’s going on.

“I thought Hephaestion would be your type. He is kind, strong of body and of mind, enjoys reading, Kremnoan, if that matters.”

Phainon doesn’t know whether to laugh or cry, how would he even begin to explain that ‘Mydeimos, it’s not as shallow as you being my type. My type is what it is because meeting you has fundamentally changed what I find attractive in a person. I just realized that it doesn’t matter if I found someone who’s like you, because they still won’t be you. I want you, specifically!’

“Forget about my type.” Phainon says, because types were dumb to begin with and it really doesn’t matter any more. “What kind of person do you find attractive, Mydei?”

“Not this again. I thought you’d let it go already,” Mydei growls, annoyed. “Why are you so obsessed with this?”

Because Phainon is jealous! Because his heart is dark, twisted, ugly, and full of resentment over things he cannot control, like who Mydei’s other friends are. That he has a deep, urgent, almost obsessive need to know whether Mydei is attracted to Hephaestion, and what Hephaestion has that Phainon doesn’t? What can Phainon change about himself for Mydei to look at him with romantic interest?

Hephaestion is just a scapegoat, Phainon knows. He’d equally despise anyone in the same position. It’s just easier to find a target for his ire, for now.

“ *HKS* ,” Mydei replies.

“What?”

“A sick man should take better care of his body so that he may return to his annoying self in no time. You should rest. I’ll take care of the chores then I’ll leave.”

Without even thinking about it, Phainon finds himself reaching out to grab his wrist.

“You’re leaving, already?” Phainon says, almost desperate. For a moment, Phainon considers making himself so sick that Mydei cannot in good conscience leave him. “So you can go back to ignoring me for weeks?”

That seems to hit his weak spot, because the unshakeable pillar of stoicism otherwise known as Mydei flinches. “I wasn’t avoiding you!” He says, tone defensive. “There were just some… things I had to work out on my own.”

“Then you won’t leave me? You won’t ignore me or avoid me? Can you promise?” Phainon says, staring up at him with teary eyes. He hadn’t meant to almost cry, it’s just that the thought of going back to whatever that was overwhelmed him.

Mydei sighs, before stooping down to meet Phainon eye to eye. “You’re really not yourself when you’re sick, Deliverer. Should I record this and show you when you get better? You’ll be so embarrassed.”

Who’s to say, perhaps Phainon had always been like this. Perhaps he was just good at putting on a facade to appear unbothered and in control.

Mydei’s gaze softens, amber eyes peering at him almost fondly as they stray to his neck. “You’re still wearing the choker… you must really like it.”

Of course he does, it was a gift from Mydei, how could Phainon not like it? When Mydei reaches out a finger to tug underneath the choker, Phainon offers no resistance and lets his head roll with the motion, almost nuzzling his face into Mydei’s hand.

The hand pauses, and then Mydei chuckles, low and warm. “You really are like a dog.”

Huh, that was the most affection Mydei had used to address him in a long time. Is that what Mydei likes? Does he like people who are like dogs? Phainon could bark for him.

“Are you free this Saturday?”

“For you, I’m always free.” Phainon finds himself saying on instinct, before his brow furrows and he sighs, dropping his head back onto the pillow. “Actually no… I’m not.” He says, remembering his prior commitment. “You know the time you went clothes shopping with me? I used Aglaea’s money to pay for those items. So apparently, that was not out of goodwill. Aglaea expects me to pay it back by working for her.”

“Lady Aglaea is a fashion designer, right? What is she asking you to do?”

Phainon groans, squeezing his eyes shut. “Modelling.”

“I see…” Mydei says, before chuckling. His laughter is low and warm, like a roaring fireplace in autumn. Phainon finds himself opening an eye, if his suffering makes Mydei smile, then perhaps it isn’t so bad. “It suits you. You are very handsome.”

Phainon almost thinks he’s hallucinating, because did Mydei just praise him? He must be dreaming. “Can you say that again?”

“No.”

Alright, at least he tried.

“Why did you ask?” Phainon says.

Mydei scratches the back of his neck, looking a little embarrassed. “Hephaestion will leave Okhema soon, and it coincides with a long weekend in Castrum Kremnos. He decided it would be a great idea to gather all our old friends from Kremnos and go clubbing. I was going to ask if you wanted to join… but your thing is more important.”

It was like Phainon’s world had shattered. His Mydeimos? Clubbing? Phainon couldn’t even imagine it. His vision went blurry, his head started spinning, and he feels like he’s about to be sick.

“Clubbing?” Phainon repeats shakily.

“Yeah, Deliverer… you don’t look good.”

“I think I feel sick.”

“Easy… let’s stop talking about this. You really need to rest.” Mydei props him up gently, a warm hand on his back. The paper bag he brought his food in was shoved under Phainon’s nose in case he might throw up.

“I’m fine,” Phainon insists, he can’t let the conversation end here, he *needs* to know more, otherwise he’ll become even more unwell. “Which club?”

“Styxia.”

Styxia? Phainon has no interest in such activities, but he lives in a frat house, so of course he knows the reputation of all the clubs in town. Styxia was the place to go if you wanted to find a hookup, not just get wasted with friends!

“You really look pale… I think you should go to the doctor’s.” Mydei tells him, the warm hand on his back shifting.

“No, I don’t need a doctor.” Phainon says, scrambling after his warmth and almost falling off the bed.

“Yes, you do. I’ll ask one of your frat brothers to drive you. I rode my bike here today so I can’t take you, not in this condition.”

But he can’t do anything but watch as Mydei makes arrangements to take him to the doctors. The campus physician simply diagnoses him with an unspecified viral illness, gives him a few antipyretics to take, and orders him to take a few days off from classes to rest.

But Phainon needs more than just medicine, he feels like he’s going crazy. His emotions are so overwhelming and suffocating it’s like he can’t think of anything else but Mydei!! He imagines Mydei, red-faced and drunk on the dance floor, a nameless faceless stranger grinding up against him, touching him… exchanging whispers, giggles, Mydei showing the stranger a smile that’s normally reserved for Phainon, taking his hand, and then Mydei taking the stranger back to his home where they’ll…

And that’s when Phainon really loses his lunch.

As he hunches over the toilet bowl, covered in cold sweat and feeling like the most pathetic human being alive, Phainon can no longer deny the fact that he is deeply in love with Mydei. And while the realization was new, the feeling was not. Maybe he had always been this possessive, and was just lucky enough to never have to compete with anyone else for Mydei’s affections.

No, Phainon thinks as he pushes the sweaty bangs away from his face. This is his fault. He should never have brought up that stupid topic of asking Mydei for dating advice.

What should he do? Could he stop Mydei from going to that club somehow? What if he said that Aglaea wanted him as a model too. No, that would never fly. Mydei would text Aglaea himself, then the truth would come out and both would be mad at him. It’s fine if Aglaea is mad, she’ll forgive him eventually, he is her beloved godson, after all. But he wouldn’t be able to live if Mydei gets angry with him and stops talking to him again.

He can’t stop him, he knows Mydei too well. That man will never be happy tied down or leashed, even if that’s what Phainon wants to do so desperately.

Phainon really can’t do anything.

He can’t even seem to muster a smile for the camera as the photographer hovers around him, snapping pictures of him from different angles wearing Aglaea latest men’s collection.

After another forced smile, she looks down at her screen, mouths something that seems like a ‘yikes’, and goes to speak to Aglaea.

She stands against the wall cross-armed, wearing a dress with fine golden embroidery, hair done in delicate curls that fall to her chin. A white blazer is draped over her shoulders. Aglaea finishes her conversation with the photographer, then raises her head to address Phainon.

“Phainon, dear, perhaps you can stop trying to smile for a little while. We want to sell the clothes, not kill whoever is wearing them.”

Fine, then Phainon won’t bother trying to smile, it’s easier for him anyway. Without the effort, he just looks cold and glum the entire shoot. Still, the photographer seems satisfied, and things move quickly. Phainon is shuffled in and out of dressing rooms, getting poked, prodded and measured to ensure the outfits fit just right. Hairspray tickles his nose, and an eyeliner pencil nearly stabs his eye while he barely reacts, just sitting and waiting for this to be over.

It’s getting dark outside, Mydei should be gearing up to go to the club right now. He can’t stop thinking about what Mydei might wear, something deliberately sinful? Maybe a cropped top that exposes the sharp cut of his abs? Pants so tight they accentuate the muscles of his thighs and calves? Would he pair it with his leather biker jacket? That one always makes people go crazy. He’ll look gorgeous, of course. Mydei always does. And many people will want him, of course they will.

Phainon wants to be there, not to drink, not to dance, but just to stand next to him, let people know that Mydei is taken. He’s not, but it doesn’t stop Phainon from wanting to claim him anyway.

“We’re done, you can go out now.” The makeup artist, a kind looking girl with pink pigtails peers at him, snapping Phainon back to reality. “You have really nice skin! Hardly any pores at all.”

Phainon mumbles his thanks, and walks, zombie-like back out into the shooting area, where Aglaea and the photographer are leaning over pictures in a laptop.

“Excellent work today,” Aglaea says, turning around to face him. “This should be the last outfit of the day and we’re done. Consider your debt repaid.”

“I was really worried when Aglaea said she was using her godson for free labour, but you’re a real heartthrob. And that gloomy, bad-boy demeanor is an absolute ladykiller. You’re gonna go far, kid.” The photographer slinks

up to him, cat-like blue eyes assessing him up and down. “Pst, if law school doesn’t work out and you want a modelling gig that’s actually paid. Feel free to keep in touch.” She slips a name card into his shirt pocket.

“Cifera,” Aglaea says in a warning tone. “Are you trying to poach my godson?”

“No ma’am!” Cipher says, winking to the very confused Phainon.

The shoot goes smoothly just like the rest of the sessions, with Phainon mostly standing there and performing a few poses when instructed by Aglaea. She seems to be pleased with the outcome, nodding after only less than half an hour.

“I think we’ve got all the shots we need. You’re free to go, Phainon, we’ll take care of the rest from here.”

Phainon looks at his phone, it’s not even 10PM.

“Yes, I told you it would last till midnight, but it looks like we’re done earlier than expected, thanks to your efficiency today.” Aglaea walks up to him, smiling softly like she just read his mind. “Any Saturday night plans?”

Phainon’s shoulders slump over. “No…”

“Pardon me for prying, but I don’t suppose you had a fight with Mydei?” Aglaea asks with an amused lilt, hand on her chin.

Phainon starts, how would she even know that? “Huh? No!”

Aglaea smiles, patting him on the shoulders like he’s a little kid. “Just a lucky guess. He’s the only one who could put you in such a bad mood. Of course, you ended up taking excellent photos, but as your godmother, I don’t like seeing you so upset. You look best when you’re smiling.”

Phainon does appreciate her attempt to cheer him up, but how can she understand the magnitude of his fumble? He smiles weakly at her. “Thanks, Aglaea, I’ll keep that in mind.”

“A real smile, not this fake one you’ve been showing us all evening,” Aglaea grips his cheeks in her hand, forcing Phainon to make a funny face like a pufferfish. “Whatever it is, I'm sure you can talk it out with Mydeimos. He’s a very nice boy and would be more than willing to hear you out.”

“B-but,” Phainon says, voice coming out distorted from his puckered lips. “What if he doesn’t feel the same way?”

“You are so called ‘best friends’, aren’t you? If he is the right one, he’ll accept you as you are.”

Phainon’s clouded gaze begins to clear, like storm clouds parting after the rain. The shimmer in his eyes returns, the dark expression replaced by something cautiously hopeful.

“I guess I won’t know if I don’t try. Thank you Aglaea, I just remembered that I did have Saturday night plans after all.”

Aglaea nods. “If you head outside, you’ll find a taxi. It was supposed to be your ride home, but if you have somewhere else to be…”

Phainon nods, just about to run off before he pauses in his tracks. “Aglaea… this outfit… can I take it with me?”

“Of course,” Aglaea smiles. “I was planning to give it to you anyway. It looks good on you.”

“Thank you once again, Aglaea!” Phainon gives a hasty wave, sprinting off in the direction of the exit.

“Oh my, working with young people is so invigorating,” Cipher sighs, placing her chin in her palm. “Reminds me of myself when I was a little kitten.”

“This is who he’s talking about, by the way,” Aglaea hides her coy smile behind her hand as she shows Cipher Mydei’s profile picture.

“WOW!” The photographer exclaims, eyes widening to the size of dinner plates. “I’ll give you your godson back if you let me poach his little boyfriend instead.”

Chapter End Notes

Sad wet dog Phainon is my favourite flavour just saying. Thank you so much for reading and please leave a kudos or a comment if you enjoyed, I’d appreciate it so much!
The next chapter should be out tomorrow/day after followed by the final one really soon. I’ve been writing like a possessed person trying to finish before the 3.4 story update because I KNOW I’M going to crash out. Not just Phainon, ME!!

Chapter 2: Mydei

Chapter Summary

> “So…” Hephaestion tilts his head “Can we talk about the big white puppy from yesterday?” He asks, breaking the ice with all the subtlety of a sledgehammer. “Both of you acted super weird, he looked like he wanted to kill me if I breathed at him wrong, and you were trying too hard to pretend that it’s a normal thing for him to do.”
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Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There is no word for love in the Kremnoan dictionary. But that’s not to say that Kremnoan people don’t feel love.

To Mydei, love is a quiet thing. Love does not demand attention, love does not try to possess, love does not require reciprocation.

Love is the way his mother buys extra pomegranates when she goes to the market, knowing they’re his favourite. Love is her calloused hands holding his as she teaches him how to strum a guitar. Love is when he makes sure there’s a warm meal on the table after she comes home from a long day at work.

He is not sure when he fell in love with Phainon.

It was a slow process. At first Mydei cooks for him because he is a danger to himself and others in the kitchen, besides, he was used to shopping and cooking for two. With time he finds himself inexplicably charmed by the boyish grin that Phainon gives him whenever he eats something he particularly enjoys. Mydei becomes comfortable with how observant Phainon is, able to somehow notice when he's having a bad day - or when that scumbag he calls a father gets ahold of his phone number again, and proposes some stupid competition to take his mind off the situation. He respects how he effortlessly navigates social situations with a smile and a laugh, pulling people to his side like a force of gravity. Phainon is handsome too, fluffy hair, sparkling blue eyes like the sky, and a sunny grin that never seems to falter no matter the situation.

A guy like Phainon effortlessly integrates into college life, becoming friends with nearly everyone regardless of background. Meanwhile Mydei… he's quite used to being disliked, used to hushed whispers when he passes by, and used to glances that flick away the moment he meets their eye. Unfortunately, the Kremnoans still have a reputation for being ruthless brutes, and he's sure his appearance doesn't help. But as long as the few he holds close to his heart know the real Mydeimos, the opinions of irrelevant people don't matter to him. Mydei shields himself with this like armour, and walks with his head held high.

And yet, this *idiot* …

Mydei ducks behind the wall, hiding himself from view as he listens to Phainon tear a couple of 2nd years from the business course a new one because they were talking shit about Mydei without having even spoken to him before. He can't hear what Phainon is saying, it's all muffled, but it is loud, and it is bold to the point that students are turning around to stare. It's embarrassing for him and Mydei wants to tell him to stop. He doesn't need anyone to defend him, doesn't *want* anyone to. But yet a traitorous warmth blooms inside his chest, an unfamiliar, terrifying feeling that Mydei doesn't want to acknowledge just yet.

But Phainon is the campus' golden boy, beloved by everyone, they don't even get along and he's sure most people would think that Phainon is out of his league. Defending Mydei is detrimental to Phainon's good reputation

and there's really no benefit to it at all. Maybe if he at least bragged about it to Mydei at home then he'd understand that his motive was to get into Mydei's good graces or at least have him indebted to Phainon. But no, that isn't the case at all. Phainon never brings it up, it's like it didn't even happen.

It's too late, the seed has already been planted in Mydei's heart. Things that he never expected to feel, things like *hope* , things like *want* .

Kind of pathetic, falling in love with the first person he meets at college. But it is what it is.

It's okay that Phainon does not love him back.

And when Phainon, smiling and looking at him with those gigantic puppy eyes, leans over the table and begs "Pleasseeee Mydei! Help me out! I really want to start dating!" Completely oblivious to the candidate that's sitting right in front of him, Mydei has no choice but to agree, even though it feels like his heart is being gouged out with a fork. Because love is quiet devotion, love gives and it does not ask for reciprocation, love is invisible sacrifices.

But Mydei is just a man, he has his limits too. When Phainon tells him, with that infuriating smile, no thoughts head empty, that his type is "Someone like you, maybe? But not you, of course." something inside him cracks.

The thought plays inside his head round and round like an infinite loop. Why not Mydei? How can Phainon describe his ideal partner and then overlook the very single Mydei that is in front of him. It eats at him like a parasite that doesn't want to let go, and while Mydei plays it off casually, he realizes that he's not as invulnerable as he thinks.

For the sake of his sanity, Mydei has to take a break and get his thoughts together. It starts with small things, changing his gym hours so they won't overlap, making (rather flimsy) excuses to decline his invitations to hang out, even taking the long way around to campus so that he doesn't

accidentally run into him. It is cowardly. Utterly shameful. He is a Kremnoan raised with courage and pride, one who should face his problems head on and not slink away like a dog with its tail between its legs. But the shame is more tolerable than the bitter ache he feels when he thinks about Phainon right now.

And perhaps Mydei is just stupid because after all of this he still wants Phainon to be happy. When his childhood friend Hephaestion gets in contact with him because he's in Okhema for a week on a research trip, Mydei immediately thinks that perhaps he could set them up. Hephaestion is similar to Mydei in many ways, they are both stubborn, headstrong, resilient like weeds, perhaps that is why they became such good friends. Yet Hephaestion is gentle in ways that Mydei is not, soft curves where Mydei is hard muscle, like Mydei, yet not like him.

It feels like Mydei is repeatedly sticking his own hand into the claw trap, and then doing it again before the injuries can heal. But it feels right for them to meet each other, the two people Mydei considered his closest friends may fall in love with each other. Wouldn't that be beautiful?

And as long as the people he loves are happy, Mydei could be happy too, eventually.

Yeah, no, *fuck* .

If Mydei could travel back in time, he'd strangle himself from a few days ago. Why did he think this was a good idea, again?

Actually, he'd go even further and stop himself from accepting Aglaea's invitation to take Phainon clothes shopping in the first place.

What business does Phainon have showing up at his doorstep dressed like *that* ?

It's annoying how good he looks in the white shirt that tightens around his broad shoulders and tapers at his narrow waist. The collar opening just

enough to be sinful but not overly scandalous. Half tucked into black jeans, it strikes the perfect balance between casual and deliberate. It's the same with his hair, half of it pushed back, the other half left to fall in soft waves over his brow and cheekbones. Trying, but not too hard. Messy, but intentionally so.

Unfairly handsome, 100 percent.

And then there was the worst (best) part of it all, the choker, the strip of dark leather against his slender neck. It stands out against his pale skin, draws attention to his jaw, the elegant slope of his throat. The sun tattoo, its light yellow normally camouflaged against his skin, is all the more visible from underneath it. It's like a temptation, waiting for Mydei to grab the choker like a leash and pull, to see what's underneath.

"Do… do I look okay?" Phainon asks, shyer than usual. Mydei realizes he's been staring too long.

"You look nice." Mydei just says, like he hadn't been caught fawning.

Mydei can't help but think that if Phainon dressed like this all the time, he'd be dangerous. The boy who would become the object of every foolish crush on campus. The kind of male lead in romance novels that would have his own dedicated fanclub. Hell, even Mydei's heart would have skipped a beat.

Is that so surprising, though? He literally picked the clothes based on what he would personally find attractive.

So this was all his fault, he's got nobody to blame but himself. He should have just let Phainon keep wearing that stupid neon yellow t-shirt and purple dromas printed pants. Mydei has made his bed and now has to lie in it.

"Phainon, this is Hephaestion." Mydei sees him almost missing the cue to shake Hephaestion's hand and wonders if the latter has really got him that flustered.

His worries that his two best friends won't get along dissipate as things dissolve into friendly banter.

"His highness speaks a lot about you."

"His highness?"

"Oh, it's just a nickname we used to call him in high school. It sort of stuck."

They both turn to grin at him, Mydei rolls his eyes in response. It is a bit of a silly nickname, but he doesn't mind it too much. It reminds him of his schooling days, of simpler times.

Mydei hears Phainon laugh, loud and forced, and hopes that he's not misunderstanding. Him and Hephaestion are just friends, extremely close friends yes, like brothers, almost, but nothing more.

"And how long have you known Mydei?"

Hephaestion throws an arm around Mydei's shoulder. He scowls, having half a mind to shrug him off, but he seems to attract human blankets because the last time he remembers, all his friends are this touchy. He hasn't told Hephaestion about his intention to set him up with Phainon, which does make Mydei feel a little bad. But he's hoping to have things develop organically between them.

"Hephaestion is pursuing his studies in anthropology, and is in town this week on a study trip curating artifacts at the museum." Mydei explains, watching Phainon closely for the glint in his eyes that will indicate his interest. "Given your… hobbies in antiques, I thought you might get along."

There, he's done his part in lighting the first spark. Phainon smiles in response, but it's the kind of smile he gives to strangers. Tight, controlled, almost fake. It's very different from his real smile, the one he shows to Mydei.

“It’s surprising that Mydei hasn’t mentioned you to me.”

“ *HKS* !” Mydei exclaims in rage before he can think. It’s true that he doesn’t talk an awful lot about his life in Kremnos, but that was because his childhood held rather unpleasant memories for him. He’s definitely mentioned Hephaestion and his other friends at least once or twice. What is this *HKS* doing?

“No worries, I think it’s cute.” Hephaestion says cheerfully, and Mydei internally sighs in relief. Despite this disaster of a man, Hephaestion is taking it all in stride. He truly is much more patient than Mydei could ever be.

Dinner is quieter than he’s used to. With the yapper named Phainon on his right and the chatterbox named Hephaestion on his left, Mydei expected a livelier affair. He stays silent throughout most of the meal unless being directly addressed, this was a chance for Phainon and Hephaestion to get to know each other. Mydei can’t help but wonder if he had gone wrong somewhere, whether he should have informed Phainon that he was trying to set him up, first.

“What do you think about Hephaestion?” Mydei takes the opportunity to question him as Phainon still insists on helping with the cleaning, even though he’s technically a guest here. But Mydei of all people knows that the more you try to say no to him, the more you won’t be able to, so he just allows Phainon to do what he wants.

“He’s nice,” Phainon says. “I like him.”

Mydei nods, taking the words at face value. Good, *great* , that is a wonderful thing! That is the sound of Mydei accomplishing his goal this evening. That is the sound of victory. He should be smug as hell.

But the lump in his throat, like someone is squeezing his windpipe. The ache in his chest and the coiling unease in his gut. This is not what victory feels like.

Mydei turns away from Phainon to put away the dishes, it's a convenient way to gather his thoughts and control his facial expressions before Phainon sees something he shouldn't.

"If you want his number, let me know. I'm sure he won't mind." The offer leaves his throat unwillingly like it's being ripped out of him but there, he's done it. That should be more than enough intervention on his end.

Mydei leaves nature to run its course, distracting himself with preparing snacks for the movie. When he returns to the living room he finds Phainon and Hephaestion, sitting together on the couch, shoulders brushing, almost touching. They're whispering something too, heads leaning close to each other, the ghost of a smirk on Hephaestion's face that usually indicates he's up to something no good.

"In my own home," he sighs, resigning that he's going to have to sit on the floor this evening.

The movie is… fine, kind of cliched, a little boring. Mydei usually finds it a challenge to stay awake during these things, but often forces himself through it for the sake of his friends. This time though, when his eyes flutter shut halfway through a jump scare, Mydei makes no effort to fight it. Horror movies are ripe conditions for cuddling and getting closer to someone, right? Maybe Phainon and Hephaestion can get even closer if there's no third wheel present. Coincidentally, Mydei won't be able to see it either, which is a plus in his eyes.

When Mydei comes to, all bleary and groggy eyed and confused, the movie is already over. His neck aches from his awkward sleeping position, and he runs his fingers through his hair to smoothen it, to little success.

"Huh, it's over?" He mumbles intelligently, still half-asleep.

Phainon is next to him, watching him closely. He does not allow himself to startle, but Mydei does blink at him, slowly, like a cat.

"Your braid is undone," Phainon says, in a tone that sounds too intimate for their current situation. "Let me help you with that." He reaches forward,

closing the distance between them, intending to wrap his fingers in Mydei's golden strands like he has done so many times before.

Except this time, a voice screams in Mydei's head. *Too close* !

Acting on instinct, Mydei jerks his head back to create distance between them, stopping right before he slams his neck into the armrest. His heart is racing, his face feels hot, he can only pray that none of those things are visible to Phainon.

"Thanks, I got it," He stands, walks, flees, into the bathroom before Phainon can say another word, getting up so quickly he makes himself dizzy in the process.

In the safety of his bathroom, Mydei leans against the sink and takes a few deep breaths before he feels like himself again. No doubt Hephaestion is going to explain his strange behaviour to Phainon, and the cat's out of the bag. Hair is sacred to a Kremnoan, only family members or someone very close, like a partner, can touch it. His mother had carefully braided his hair as a sign of her love, and combing each other's hair was a courting ritual according to ancient Kremnoan customs. As a historian he knows this and still, he lets Phainon touch his hair like an idiot.

Mydei knows he shouldn't have allowed it, knows that it means more to Mydei than it does to Phainon. But he likes the feeling of Phainon's clumsy fingers in his hair, the way the strands get tangled in his fingers and he has a tug a little to free them. He likes it when Phainon's short fingernails scratch at his scalp. He even likes the wonky excuse of a braid he had ended up with. And in the middle of the night, when he's all alone, Mydei can admit that he likes pretending they are something more than just friends.

Titans strike him down, he is a pathetic excuse of a Kremnoan. Mydei isn't really sure how he will move past this embarrassment but he is going to try. He splashes his face with some cold water, carefully braids his hair into his usual style, and then goes back out to pretend like nothing's happened.

The next morning, Mydei oversleeps. He stumbles out of his bedroom, sloppy and in a rush, only to find that breakfast has been set up for him.

“Good morning, sleepyhead.” Hephaestion says, smiling slightly. Mydei blinks at him for a moment before it comes back to him that he has a guest staying over.

“Morning, uhm, thanks.” He says, digging into the eggs and sausages that have been prepared for him. Hephaestion’s food has a certain Kremnoan style home-cooking quality that has Mydei a little nostalgic.

“It tastes like my mother’s cooking.” Gorgo, notoriously, was not a very good cook. But she made all her dishes with love, so Mydei eats it all up anyway.

“That my friend, I’ll take as a compliment.” Hephaestion pats him on the back. “It’s unlike you to oversleep, by the way. I think you already missed your first class so you might as well not go in at all. I think your attendance can take a hit.”

Mydei sighs, it can, but he’s not the type to skip class, much less oversleep.

“So…” Hephaestion tilts his head “Can we talk about the big white puppy from yesterday?” He asks, breaking the ice with all the subtlety of a sledgehammer. “Both of you acted super weird, he looked like he wanted to kill me if I breathed at him wrong, and you were trying too hard to pretend that it’s a normal thing for him to do.”

That wasn’t his fault! It was Phainon’s fault for acting weird. “I… so…” he desperately tries to change the subject. “I guess my matchmaking failed?”

Hephaestion blinks at him incredulously. Once, then twice. “Excuse me?” He says. “That was you *matchmaking* ? Matchmaking me with who? My future murderer?”

“Surely you exaggerate.” Mydei rolls his eyes.

“That’s because his eyes fill with stars the moment you look his way.” Hephaestion grumbles under his breath. *“It must be a skill to misread a situation so spectacularly.”*

“You did not see the look on his face when he found out I was sleeping over here,” Hephaestion says out loud instead. “I saw my life flash before my eyes.”

Mydei frowns, as though that was a completely new discovery for him. “That’s a shame…” Mydei says quietly. “I hoped you two would get along as my best friends.”

“Oh, I’m sure we’d get along just fine once he sees I’m not a threat.”

“A threat to what?” Mydei frowns, his eyes immediately roving across Hephaestion’s slender frame and skinny arms. He doubted Hephaestion could match either of them in physical strength. Hephaestion hugs himself, immediately offended by the insinuation.

“Oh sweet Mydeimos, you can’t possibly be this daft.” Hephaestion looks torn on whether to slap Mydei or to slap himself. “Let me just spell it out plainly for you, Phainon was staring at *you* the whole evening.”

Mydei crosses his arms over his chest stubbornly. “I did not notice that.”

“Oh trust me, he did not like to share. You’ve snatched up quite the possessive little doggy.”

“...He can be quite dog-like, now that you mentioned it.” Mydei muses almost fondly.

Hephaestion looks like he wanted to rip his hair out, surely that cannot be the only thing he takes away from this conversation.

“But anyway, you’re mistaken.” Mydei continues, oblivious to the torment he is putting Hephaestion through. “He doesn’t like me that way, we’ve talked about it.”

“You have?” Hephaestion raises a disbelieving eyebrow. “And did he explicitly use the words ‘I have no romantic inclinations towards you, Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos.’ in that order?”

“...Not exactly, but the message was clear enough. He said that I was his type, but not me. That was why I tried to introduce him to you.”

“Ah.” Hephaestion says, pauses, nods like he just received the answer to a particularly perplexing puzzle. “I understand the situation now.”

Mydei gives him a look, unconvinced, Hephaestion only smiles at him. “If I tell you that I think you’re wrong, and that Phainon is down abysmal for you, would you believe me?”

“No. You’ve been making statements like that for years and it’s never been true.”

“On the contrary,” Hephaestion whispers under his breath. “It’s always been true and you are just wrong.”

But on the outside he smiles wider. “Mydeimos, may I request a favour.”

Mydei looks suspicious about this sudden change in topic, sentences that start with ‘Mydeimos’ rarely end with anything good. But he’s somewhat relieved at the change in subject anyway. “Ask.”

“This weekend coincides with a public holiday in Kremnos. I’ve decided I want to try Okheman clubbing.”

“Go by yourself.” Mydei replies immediately.

Hephaestion gasps like he’s been struck “Mydeimos! You said you would grant me a favour.” he sulks. “Come on, it’ll be fun! We’ll invite all the old gang, Leonnius, Ptolemy, Perdikkas, Peucesta, it’ll be our reunion!”

“A reunion? At a nightclub?” Mydei repeats, disdain dripping from every word.

“Do invite Phainon as well,” Hephaestion says, completely steamrolling over Mydei.

Mydei blinks. “Clubbing isn’t his thing either.”

“Trust me, if you’re there. He’ll come. Come on, I’ll handle the invitations, the bookings, all of it. You just invite him.” Hephaestion says insistently.

Mydei isn’t sure what plan he has cooking up this time. Hephaestion has always been like that, sly, cheeky, a real trickster. But one thing is true, once he makes up his mind, he’ll stop at nothing to bug Mydei until he gets his way.

Come to think of it, he and Phainon are extremely similar, in that regard. Had he misread things so badly? Would they really not like each other? But they have so much in common, whilst Mydei and Phainon are like polar opposites.

“Fine.” Mydei sighs, regretting his life choices. “I’ll ask him.”

“Great,” Hephaestion says, he doesn’t rub his hands with glee, but he might as well have.

The pulsing of the strobe lights and the loud thumping of the bass worsens Mydei’s headache and reminds him why he can’t stand nightclubs. The place is crowded already, sweaty bodies grinding against each other, drinks being chugged and spilled on the floor, the air smelling like cheap perfume.

It’s been ages since he’s last seen his old friends, and although Mydei is happy to be reunited again, he wished it was under better conditions. He can’t even speak to them without shouting over the music. Somehow Leonnius is already drunk, spinning around the dance floor with Hephaestion having the time of their lives.

Mydei leans against the seat of his booth, legs spread in a languid sprawl, drink in hand. Pomegranate juice with milk, his favourite, a wonder this

place even sells it.

He dressed up for the occasion, Hephaestion had insisted. A scarlet tailored shirt with intricate gold patterns that practically clings to his shoulders, sleeves rolled up to reveal bare forearms, tucked loosely into fitted black pants. The top buttons are undone, revealing the tight black turtleneck he is wearing underneath, stretched tight over his collarbones like a second skin. A golden chain hangs around his neck, catching the light, and dramatic earrings with sapphires embedded in them glint from his ears. They are gifts from his mother, a relic of Kremnoan culture. While normally a bit too flashy for his daily style, it works perfectly with what he's wearing tonight. Even his hair is done up nicely, top half braided from both temples, meeting in a half ponytail fixed with a blood red gem.

He looks pretty good. It's definitely more of an effort than he usually makes to go out.

Too bad Phainon isn't here to see it.

He did understand why. Aglaea's modelling job was infinitely more important, especially when he owed her. Plus, Mydei can't say he was jumping for joy at the idea of watching Phainon get flirted with all evening by random strangers. Assuming that he's still actively looking for a partner. So perhaps this was for the best.

That HKS needs to take better care of himself anyway. He was acting weird last weekend at dinner, then he acted even weirder when he was sick. Mydei can't make heads nor tails of his recent behavior.

"Careful," Hephaestion says, suddenly beside him, cheeks flushed with exertion. "If you keep brooding like that you're going to have half the club falling at your feet."

Mydei gives him a withering look. "Shut up and go back to dancing."

"Don't look so grumpy," Hephaestion laughs, taking a seat beside him and putting his arm around Mydei. "Tonight is for you."

“What?” Mydei’s ideal weekend night is staying at home reading, or baking, or playing guitar, or hanging out with Phainon.

Huh, he wonders when that made the list of his ideal weekend plans?

“I want you to forget about Phainon for a moment.” Hephaestion’s accusation feels like a slap in the face, considering that he actually had been thinking of him.

“I’m not thinking about him,” Mydei lies.

“Liar. You look hot as hell, too hot to waste just sitting here. Go on the dance floor, have fun, meet someone pretty.”

“I think I’m fine,” Mydei rolls his eyes. Unlike Phainon, he doesn’t care for a quick hookup. He’s quite happy being single.

“Alright, then at least go get us some drinks. We’re running out and you know how prickly Perdikkas is when he doesn’t have anything to mix.”

He nudges Perdikkas, who simply nods in agreement. “I’m about to start mixing the peanuts.” He says with a straight face.

Mydei huffs. “Alright,” At least it gives him something to do.

Mydei grumbles as he pushes through the dancing crowd, making apologies when necessary. It’s impossible not to make contact with other people in a place as dense as this, but some of these touches don’t feel accidental. A delicate hand flits across his chest, pausing briefly on his bicep before moving on, someone else backs into him, uncomfortably close before finally stumbling away.

He steps into something sticky and Mydei feels eternally grateful that he decided to wear his combat boots today. It would be a shame if he were to dirty his nice dress shoes in a place like this.

By the time he reaches the bar, on the other side of the club, Mydei feels like he’s fought through a warzone. Luckily, he is tall and conspicuous

enough to catch the bartender's attention easily, and manages to order without much trouble.

Now comes the next ordeal, getting back to his table.

Mydei is hardly able to walk two steps before somebody clumsily runs their entire body into him. It doesn't knock him over, Mydei is far too sturdy for that, but it does spill the drinks he is carefully holding. He can do nothing but watch in slow motion as the red liquid tilts over and spills. At the very least, karma dictates it should spill on the bastard who had bumped into him in the first place, but that fucker just twirls away, laughing without a care in the world.

No, life isn't fair, it spills on an innocent bystander who had been next to him. Mydei can only watch, horrified, as the red liquid blooms across the front of his crisp white shirt like a bloodstain.

When will this night end already?

Mydei steels his jaw, he would understand if the man cussed him out, or even punched him. But instead, the man laughs.

"Haha." It's high pitched, breathless with disbelief. "I guess I needed to buy a new shirt anyway."

"I'm sorry," Mydei apologizes sincerely. He sets the now empty glasses on the countertop and grabs a few tissues, handing them to the man.

"It's not your fault," He grabs the tissues with muffled thanks, trying to dab away the worst of the stains with them. Mydei winces as the size of the red blob only grows and grows.

It absolutely is his fault, there is no denying it. Although someone had practically rammed into him, it was he who had spilled the drinks.

"Can I… can I help you with that?" He asks, not able to watch this trainwreck any longer.

The stranger shrugs, leaning close to him. A little too close, actually. But Mydei holds his tongue, knowing it's his fault they're even in this situation, and focuses his attention on trying to get the worst of the stains out while keeping as much distance as possible.

"You know, it was a terrible night," The man starts, and Mydei feels a jolt of guilt. There he is making someone's already horrible night worse. "But… I think it's starting to get better."

"What a strange thing to say to someone who just spilled his drink on you," Mydei immediately says on instinct. He doesn't expect the stranger to laugh again.

"Lucky me, getting a drink spilled on by someone as handsome as you. What's your name, by the way? Mine's Alexander."

Mydei looks up cautiously, finding Alexander staring back at him. How had he not noticed it before, the man's interested gaze straying up and down his face and body, the slight flush in his cheeks, and the curl of his lip.

Mydei pulls away, just in time to see Alexander's hand hovering over where his arm had been. Looks like he acted just in time.

"I fear my kindness is being mistaken for something else," Mydei says, taking a step back. "I apologize once more for the accident. I will leave some money with the bartender as compensation."

"Wait, don't go." Alexander reaches out and Mydei jerks backwards, not comfortable with being touched. But before he can open his mouth to rip this rather handsy stranger a new one, someone steps in front of him.

That strong back, the snowy white hair is familiar, but everything else isn't as a deep voice growls, low and dangerous.

"Are you bothering Mydei?"

Mydei can only blink in disbelief. That is Phainon's voice, but it sounds completely different from how he normally speaks. Dark, guttural, filled

with killing intent. A bit too dramatic for someone Mydei is able to deal with himself.

“Deliverer, it’s alright, I spilled my drink on him.” Mydei tries to appease him by touching him on the shoulder. Apparently, that triggers something in Phainon, because his head turns around, blue eyes so intense they make Mydei stop in his tracks.

Phainon grabs his outstretched wrist, the grip is tight, domineering, possessive, his fingers dig into Mydei’s wrist and it hurts.

Mydei purses his lips, something is wrong.

“Let’s go, Phainon.” He’s got so many questions, and he’s not sure what’s going on. Phainon’s sudden appearance looking like *this* is such a shock to him. But Mydei knows he should defuse the situation first before things go out of hand. He takes Phainon’s hand with his free one, squeezing lightly to let him know it’s okay. He sees Phainon’s head follow his movements before he nods quietly, and he exhales a quiet sigh of relief when Phainon follows him obediently.

Mydei quickly finds an empty side room, one that’s relatively free from dancers, drunks and loud music, and drags Phainon inside with him. Phainon is still holding tightly onto his hand, the more Mydei tries to pull away, the tighter he grabs. So Mydei decides that it’ll be safer to just keep holding hands for now.

“Phainon…” Mydei keeps his voice soft, low, gentle so as not to startle him. “What are you doing here?”

Phainon’s hands are trembling as he raises his head to look up at Mydei, his eyes are glossy, as though they might overspill with tears at any moment. Mydei doesn’t know what to do with this new Phainon, this emotionally volatile, dangerous Phainon that he can’t read. He’s not even sure what had changed between them these last few weeks.

“Who was that guy? What were you doing with him?” Phainon asks, his voice back to normal but choked, like getting the words out pained him.

Answering his questions truthfully would be a good start.

“Just a stranger,” He says. “I accidentally spilled my drink on him and was trying to help. Unfortunately, he got a little too touchy and I was going to tell him off, and then you showed up. What’s with the outfit, by the way? You an idol now or something?” Mydei teases.

It’s a totally new look for Phainon, black shirt, wide open at the collar to reveal the second tattoo that runs across his chest like a golden chain that Mydei rarely gets to see. A black ribbon choker wrapped around his neck and a spiky ear cuff that he couldn’t possibly have picked out himself. His short hair is styled and partially tied up into a cute little ponytail, and he’s wearing a little makeup too. He had obviously rushed here from Aglaea’s photoshoot, but Mydei couldn’t figure out why.

Phainon smiles shakily despite himself. “Don’t try to change the subject.” He was standing so close to Mydei, one hand still tightly holding on, and the other hand now grabbing at the lapels of his shirt. “I ran into your friends when I came in. They told me they sent you to grab drinks, and wondered why you were taking so long. So I went looking for you, and it looks like I came just in time, or else… or else…”

“Else what?” Mydei says, still trying to make sense of this strange behavior.

“Else I would have been too late,” Phainon mumbles darkly, curling his hand into a fist until he’s clenching Mydei’s shirt so tightly that the fabric wrinkles.

“I think you should explain yourself,” Mydei finally says. “You’ve been acting weird, ever since that dinner with Hephaestion.”

To his surprise, Phainon blushes, the red stands out starkly against his pale skin and black outfit. “Promise me that if I tell you the truth, you won’t leave?”

It’s not like Mydei is going anywhere anyway, with the way that Phainon is so tightly clinging on to him. But when Phainon looks at him like that with

those big blue teary eyes, bottom lip quivering slightly, cheeks slightly pink. Well, Mydei would hear him out even if he confessed to murder.

“I won’t leave,” Mydei promises, he brushes his knuckle against the cool metal of Phainon’s earring, Phainon’s head immediately tilts to the side, chasing his touch. Mydei’s heart seizes again he’s… he’s really cute. Mydei thinks if he ever gets the chance he’d really enjoy running his fingers through that soft white hair as Phainon nuzzles into his hand. “Tell me what’s on your mind.”

Phainon’s breath hitches, and he lets go of Mydei’s shirt, his free hand joining the one that’s holding tightly to Mydei’s hand. “Mydei…” his voice is trembling, his eyes nearly flit away to look at the wall before he regains his courage and stares straight at him, the power they have is devastating. Pupils of sky blue, almost glowing in the dim club light, beam straight into Mydei.

“Mydei, I think I have a crush on you.”

Mydei’s brain decides to give up and call it a day. It’s like his heart races into overdrive, the blood rushing through his head so quickly that his own heartbeat completely overshadows the sound of the club’s music.

“HUH?” Honestly, he would have been less surprised if Phainon confessed to murder. “Deliverer, are you drunk? Did my friends give you anything to drink?” That is the only logical explanation.

“I’m not drunk,” Phainon begs, holding on to his hand so tightly that Mydei feels his blood circulation getting cut off. “Yes, your friend, I think his name was Perdikkas did give me a drink, but it was sweet, nothing like alcohol.”

“You idiot!” Mydei huffs. “A single drink from Perdikkas could down an elephant.” Phainon has to be drunk, there was no way he could say something so outrageous otherwise. The nerve, the audacity of this man to drop something so shocking without warning him first!

“You are not being yourself, I am taking you home.” Mydei says decisively. The idea of Phainon being here in this nightclub, so open, vulnerable, looking like this? Yeah, they need to leave asap.

“I really am telling the truth,” Phainon’s voice cracks. He steps closer to Mydei, backing him up against the wall, pinning him to the spot. Someone dressed so dangerously has no right acting this pathetic and Mydei is struck dumb by the absolutely unbelievable situation he’s found himself in.

“Mydei…” One of Phainon’s hands is still holding him in a death grip, the other creeping to the other side, finding Mydei’s other hand, and pinning both of his wrists to the wall. Mydei twitches his hands, Phainon only strengthens his grip. It hurts, he might get bruises on them tomorrow. He already knows this but Phainon is freakishly strong, Mydei might still be able to escape the grip if he struggles, but even he hesitates to use that excessive amount of force in this situation.

Instead, he waits and sees what Phainon will do next.

“Please believe me,” Phainon’s head falls onto his shoulder, his hair obscuring his face so that Mydei can’t see his facial expression. But his voice, for lack of a better term, sounds wet. “You smell so good, Mydei…” Phainon turns his nose into the crook of his neck and Mydei feels a sharp inhale of breath, followed by a long sigh. Is the deliverer seriously *sniffing* him right now??? “You look so sexy. I feel sick, knowing that other people saw you like this.”

“Phainon, this isn’t you.” Mydei warns. For all the time he’s known him, the deliverer has always been very restrained, always keeping his proper distance, armed with that same sunny smile and unshakeable cheer. Mydei sometimes catches glimpses of it though, that dark look in his eyes when he is displeased, subtly possessive behaviour when he tries to prove that it is he that knows Mydei best. But never… never to this extent.

Phainon laughs wetly, Mydei feels warm dampness on his shoulder, where Phainon’s head is buried in “What if I told you that I was always like this? Always so scared to lose what belongs to me. Would you not like me anymore? Would you stop being my friend?”

He sounds so sad, like someone who lost so much and is scared of losing again. Mydei doesn't know where this is coming from all of a sudden, but he knows that Phainon is in desperate need of reassurance right now. "Phainon, can you let go of my wrists so I can hug you?"

That does the trick, the pressure on his wrists releases simultaneously, and Mydei takes a second to rub them, grimacing at the pins and needles in his fingers. Phainon stares at him in disbelief, eyes a little bloodshot, his cheeks wet with tear tracks, more obvious due to the areas where the foundation has been rubbed off. "Yeah! Please, please do, hug me, that is. I really want your hug."

Mydei doesn't need to be told twice, he wraps his arms around Phainon, feeling the warm body stiffen beneath him. His clothes are high quality, as soft as silk. He squeezes slightly as Phainon's firm muscles twitch in response to his touch. One hand lightly weaves into Phainon's hair, messing up the carefully styled strands. Phainon doesn't seem to mind though, as he pushes his head into Mydei's palm. "Phainon, I'm not going anywhere. No matter what you're like, I'll always be your friend."

"Can I be more than just your friend? Mydei, I really really like you. Can you find it within yourself to like me too?"

Mydei huffs. "You're being stupid, deliverer. There is nothing to consider. I already like you." Mydei does not go out of his way to hang out with people he doesn't like, does not bother to cook for them, does not wallow in despair at the thought of them liking someone else. In hindsight, he can't believe he tried to matchmake this mess with Hephaestion, of all people. It looks like he owes his friend an apology.

"Really?" Phainon asks, sounding like if he had a tail, he'd be wagging it right now. "Then can I kiss you?"

Mydei makes a noise he's sure he's never made in his life, something that borders a squawk. Phainon seems to take his speechlessness as implicit approval, or perhaps he's just so eager to kiss him that he just can't wait anymore. Because before he can exclaim another outraged 'what?' Phainon's lips crash onto his.

Phainon kisses like he does everything else: eager, passionate, and full of enthusiasm. His lips slot onto Mydei's and refuse to let go, almost frantically, like Mydei will disappear if he lets go. He's so aggressive that it's almost impossible for Mydei to draw a breath. Phainon's a sloppy kisser, too, he overshoots sometimes in his excitement, catching the corner of Mydei's lip, or even his nose. But his lips are soft, his perfume smells nice, and he tastes sweet. When Phainon parts his lips and his tongue shyly brushes against Mydei's, the taste is familiar.

Mydei breaks away when he feels like his face, and heart, are about to explode, flushed and panting. The trail of saliva connecting them snaps like silk thread.

"You taste like… pomegranate juice?"

Phainon grins at him, dazzling underneath the dim club lights. "Told you I wasn't drunk."

Mydei puts his hand against his mouth, feeling how warm and numb they are. His head is still spinning, not knowing what to make of this situation. Two weeks ago, Mydei was trying to get over the fact that his feelings for Phainon were unrequited, one week ago, he was trying to matchmake him with his childhood best friend. Now, Phainon is looking at him like his world would explode without Mydei, and he gave him his first kiss.

"That was my first kiss," Mydei finds himself saying out loud instead, his face burning at the admission.

Phainon looks ecstatic, his eyes darken with something that is unmistakably lust, desire, want. "Can I give you your second one too?"

This time, Mydei is quick enough to respond. " *HKS* !" He swears, pushing Phainon's eager face away with his palm. "No." He hasn't even made his peace with the first one.

"No?" Phainon repeats, his enthusiasm turning to devastation in a flip of a coin, the light in eyes dims, extinguishes. "Mydei, you didn't like it?"

It is Mydei's style not to answer if he doesn't know what to say. He prefers thinking things through, making sense of his thoughts before giving deliberate answers. It prevents him from speaking thoughtlessly, unlike a certain deliverer. Unfortunately, Phainon misinterprets his silence.

"Was it something I did?" Phainon steps in again into Mydei's personal space, caging him in so that Mydei can't escape. "I'm sorry, that was my first kiss too. But I can try harder, I can practice, I'll get better. I'll make it feel good for you, I swear, if you give me another chance. Please don't hate me, Mydei." He speaks so quickly Mydei can't even get a word in. Phainon's fingers dig tightly and uncomfortably into Mydei's shoulders.

"Phai-"

"I'll do whatever you want me to do, just don't leave me. Don't ignore me. Don't avoid me for weeks like you did before. I can't lose you, I'm sorry. I'm really, really, sorry. Would it help if I begged? I could beg if you want me to." Warm tears drip down Phainon's eyes, rolling off his cheeks and down his chin as Mydei stares, stunned, at the mess in front of him.

This is getting out of hand, and Mydei feels a pang of guilt. It was his fault that he ignored Phainon those weeks, he didn't realize it would affect the other man so badly. He was just trying to make sense of his feelings, and maturely accept that Phainon didn't feel the same way about him. But apparently, Phainon does feel the same way about him, to a scarily obsessive degree, as a matter of fact. A part of Mydei feels happy, but the other half is afraid, this is happening too fast.

Regardless, he needs to act quickly before Phainon spirals even further.

"For gods' sake, Phainon, shut up and look at me," Mydei reaches up to clench the deliverer's chin, Phainon just blinks at him, tears still rolling from his eyes and dripping onto Mydei's hand. "I did not dislike it. I just… need some time to think about it. Can you give me that?"

Phainon nods quickly, chin still caught in Mydei's grip, he looks funny like this, flushed cheeks all squished together. "Yes, yes, I'll do anything you want."

Mydei frowns slightly, letting him go. His excessive eagerness to please Mydei is a bit concerning, and something that he definitely needs to bring up later. But this is not the time, nor the place. “I tire of this place, I’ll take you home.”

“Your home?” Phainon asks, tugging at his clothes almost pathetically.

Mydei sighs, as though he’d let Phainon go home to his crowded frat dorm in this condition. “Yes, we’ll go to my home. You’ll stay over tonight.”

Phainon seems delighted with this turn of events because he doesn’t complain, he grabs Mydei’s elbow and smiles as he lets Mydei lead them back out into the crowded dance floor.

“I’ll just tell my friends we’re leaving first,” Mydei turns around and has to shout for Phainon to hear through the strobe lights and music.

“Okay,” Phainon says. An overeager dancer bumps into Mydei’s as they make their way back, and when they turn around to apologize, Phainon holds onto Mydei’s arm tighter and makes a sound that almost seems like a growl.

Mydei turns around to look, and is shocked by what he sees. That expression is so different from the Phainon he knows that it gives him whiplash. It’s dark, angry, those blue eyes are radiating something that can only be considered as murderous intent. The errant dancer mumbles a rapid apology and leaves, disappearing back into the grinding crowd of bodies.

He internally apologizes to Hephaestion for what he’s put him through.

Finally he makes his way back to their booth, where his friends immediately lambast him with ‘where have you been?’ and knowing glances when they see who’s attached to his arm.

“I see you’ve met up with Phainon,” Perdikkas starts with a knowing glance. “He ran into the club, all out of breath and sweating like he rushed here. I gave him your drink to finish, hopefully you don’t mind.”

“Right,” Mydei says flatly. “Anyway, this *HKS* is drunk, I need to take him home. I’m leaving early for tonight, sorry.”

It’s met with the fakest gasps of surprise he has ever heard. His friends sound bored, almost like they had expected this outcome.

“Sure, sure. You do what you need to do. Let’s meet up again next time.” Hephaestion says with an all-knowing gaze.

“Mydei… you and I both know that I’m not drunk,” Phainon whispers as they finally, *finally* exit the stuffy club. The chilly night wind blowing against them feels like freedom and fresh air.

Mydei’s face flushes, and he turns his face to the side. “You want all my friends to see you like that?”

Phainon just latches onto his arm tighter. “I’m only like that around you.” he says softly. “Nobody else.”

Mydei turns his head to stare again in disbelief at the, he emphasizes, grown-ass man hanging from his arm. “Well good,” he grumbles “I… don’t think I like the idea of others seeing you that way.”

Phainon flushes, his eyes brightening, he looks like Mydei has told him the best news he’s heard all year. “And you chose me,” he says elatedly. “Out of all your friends and that guy who was trying to get close to you. Even after I showed you my ugly side and cried in front of you. You still chose me. I’m so happy!”

Mydei’s breath hitches in his throat and he has to look away quickly, feeling light headed from how hot his face suddenly feels. That is lethal, a critical hit, for sure. He quickly finds his bike among the crowd of those parked outside the club and grabs his helmet, nearly shoving it into Phainon. “I only brought one so… you take it.”

“We’re riding your bike?” Phainon repeats in awe. “I think this is the first time I’ve ever been on it.” In Okhema, walking or taking public transport is

simply easier. Mydei only rode his bike today so he has an excuse not to drink any alcohol.

Mydei swings a leg over the seat and settles in, the metal handlebars feeling cool and comfortable under his grip. He starts the ignition and the engine roars to life, like a beast waking from slumber. He looks at Phainon, still holding the helmet.

“Are you going to get on?” He scowls. What’s taking him so long? How many times has Phainon begged Mydei to let him ride on the bike in the past and now he’s hesitating.

Phainon looks at a vague point in the distance, cheeks flushing. Somehow looking the most embarrassed he’s been all evening despite the shameless things he pulled off today.

“Maybe… I should take a cab to your place instead?” Phainon asks timidly.

“Why?” Mydei asks dryly, feeling like he’s going to regret hearing the answer.

Phainon shuffles in place. “If I ride behind you, I might get a boner…”

He said it so softly, like it would get carried away by the wind and somehow not become true. But unfortunately, Mydei heard every word.

“My place is only 10 minutes away if we go fast so just deal with it,” He growls, feeling annoyed and ashamed of the way he got a little turned on by that statement. “Now get on or don’t come over at all!”

The threat seems to have done the trick, because Phainon quickly puts the helmet on and slips into position behind Mydei. His crotch twitches when it makes contact with Mydei’s tailbone, and Mydei pretends he doesn’t hear the tiniest whimper that escapes from Phainon. It’s a good thing that Mydei’s making him wear the helmet, he doesn’t want to know what kind of face he’s making right now.

Riding without a helmet is definitely not recommended but at least the city roads are quiet this Saturday night. Mydei weaves through the sparse traffic with ease, enjoying the feeling of the wind whipping through his hair and the blur of the streetlights. The night air calms him down, somewhat, clears his head and makes him feel a little more in control of his thoughts, his emotions. Even Phainon's grip seems to have relaxed slightly by the time they finally pull up to his apartment complex.

"We're here," Mydei announces, pretending that he can't feel the obvious bulge pressing into the top of his ass. "Maybe you should get off first…"

Phainon obeys, pulling off the helmet and shaking his hair out like a wet dog. The small ponytail has loosened to the point that the hair tie is barely hanging on for dear life, and Phainon takes it off, ruffling his hair in the process. The wind has blown the already pretty scandalous collar wide open, and one side of his shirt has come untucked. But he still looks devastatingly handsome, which is quite unfair really.

Mydei jolts as his eyes rove upwards, meeting Phainon's eye as he stares at him with an awestruck expression. Half embarrassed at being caught staring, half defensive from the sudden attention he barks out a "What?"

"Nothing you… you look gorgeous. I mean, you're always beautiful, Mydei, but." Phainon says along with a shaky inhale, and then he stops halfway, like words aren't enough to convey the gravity of how he really feels.

Mydei is not used to such fawning praise and shifts uncomfortably on his feet. "Let's just go inside," he grumbles.

Mydei ends up opening the door for Phainon and letting him enter first, that is only polite, and he was raised properly by his mother, thank you very much. But it's only as he walks into his own apartment and passes by the mirror in his entryway that he sees what he truly looks like.

"Fuck," Mydei swears at his reflection. The braids he had worked on so carefully had come undone, leaving wild waves curling around his ears and neck. His bangs… half of them aren't even on his face anymore, partly

swept around his ear, partly falling into his eye, a stubborn strand sticking up in the air. A total mess.

This was what Phainon saw and he still complimented him? There must be something wrong with his eyes.

“Mydei?” Phainon peeks his head around the corner when he notices that Mydei hasn’t been following him, he sees Mydei try futilely to fix his hair in the mirror and walks up to him.

“There’s a leaf in your hair,” he says. “May I…?” His question is clipped, wary, like he still remembered what happened the last time he wanted to touch Mydei’s hair.

Well of course Mydei didn’t let him touch his hair, that was when he thought Phainon had a chance with Hephaestion. It would look bad for him to be seen touching Mydei’s hair, knowing how important that was in Kremnoan culture.

But now… knowing that Phainon had feelings for him. He supposes it would be okay to let him… just once.

“Yeah sure,” Mydei says, lowering his hands. Phainon’s hands are in his hair immediately, as though he feared Mydei would take back the offer if he wasted even a second. Fingers run through his shoulder length locks, untangling the knots that the wind had put in there as gently as they were pieces of thread that could snap at any time.

“Mydei…” Phainon starts in a soft voice. “I really am sorry. I didn’t know how significant it was in Kremnoan culture to touch someone’s hair.”

“It’s fine,” Mydei says, arms crossed, head lowered down slightly enjoying the feeling of Phainon’s fingers running through his hair. “It’s not like I made an effort to tell you, it was my bad.”

“But you’ve always let me touch your hair, even before.” Phainon says. Mydei’s eyes snap open, as though he realized he’s dug himself into a hole. “Does that mean you love me?” He asks, cheekily.

Mydei ducks away all of a sudden, ignoring the pain as Phainon's hand gets caught in a tangle, ripping a couple of his hairs out. He's revealed too much. "It's late, shower and go to sleep. I'll get you some clothes you can borrow."

"Wait, Mydei." Phainon calls out to him, sounding deliriously happy as Mydei feels himself flush all the way to his ears. "Don't run away, I love you too!"

Mydei takes his sweet time in his closet, organizing things he doesn't need to before choosing some comfortable sleepwear for Phainon. Luckily, they're almost the same size, so he should be able to wear Mydei's clothes without issues. Love? Back in the club Phainon had told Mydei he had a crush on him, then, he said he liked him. Those things were very different from love. Part of him doesn't even know if Phainon really means it, or if he's mistaken infatuation, or lust, for love.

By the time he leaves the bedroom, carrying a fresh set of sleepwear, the shower is running. Phainon's clothes are folded neatly outside the bathroom and Mydei touches the fabric, it feels soft and smooth under his fingertips. Very comfortable and high quality, as expected of Aglaea.

"That HKS forgot to get a towel before he showered." Mydei murmurs under his breath. He knows there are no spare towels inside the bathroom. Well, he's sure Phainon won't mind if he comes in for a moment, it's not like guys haven't seen each other naked before.

He raps two times on the door decisively before announcing. "Deliverer, I'm coming in."

Mydei opens the door quietly and walks in, and he should have known better, he really should have known better. Phainon had told him he was going to get a boner, and Mydei had definitely felt said boner when they arrived home. What was a reasonable, virile young man going to do in the bathroom of his crush when he has a boner?

"Mydei… Mydeimos… fuck," Phainon had not heard him over the noise of the shower running, but Mydei sees everything clearly through the

transparent shower door. Phainon leaning against the wall with one elbow, the other hand wrapped around his cock, hair damp and sticking to his neck, droplets of water trickling over his abs as he chanted Mydei's name like a mantra while furiously stroking himself.

Phainon hadn't noticed him come in, he could still walk out, still pretend that he didn't see anything.

But Mydei doesn't.

He clears his throat lightly, loud enough to be heard over the running water.

Phainon gasps, blue eyes snapping wide open.

"Mydei? I…" Phainon looks horrified to have been caught in this position, like any normal person would. But his body betrays him as he looks at Mydei, who has removed his outer shirt and most of his jewelry and is left only in his tight sleeveless black turtleneck and black pants, and moans as his cock visibly twitches in his hand.

"Huh, you really are shameless, aren't you, Deliverer." Mydei doesn't know what's gotten into him either as he strolls towards Phainon. "Caught in the act and your cock only grew bigger."

Now, Mydei won't admit to spending a lot of time thinking about the male anatomy, he only knows his penis is considered bigger than most. But Phainon's is… a different beast altogether, he way his hand can barely wrap all the way around its girth, the way the engorged veins that run up its shaft are throbbing in accordance to his heartbeat, the way it seems to twitch in Phainon's hand as Mydei gets closer.

"Let me help you with that."

"I… huh…?" Huh is a rather apt answer, Mydei thinks, as he sinks to his knees in front of Phainon's weeping cock, shower water seeping into his pants as he does so. He doesn't know why he's doing this either, only that he wants to.

One hour ago, he received his first kiss, and now, he’s giving Phainon a blowjob. What's gotten into him? Mydei doesn’t have an answer for that as he takes Phainon’s cock into his mouth.

Phainon lets out a whimper that sounds very much like he wants to come but is trying to hold himself back. Mydei’s jaw feels the stretch as he takes in Phainon’s cock, getting it halfway in before he starts to feel his gag reflex kicking in. But it’s not his style to give up, and he thinks Phainon already likes it plenty from the way he’s moaning and gripping the wall like his life depends on it. So Mydei starts to move slowly, back and forth.

“Hngh… My… Mydei…” Phainon gasps, back hitting the wall so hard that it causes a thump that can probably be heard by the next door neighbour.

Mydei didn’t expect to enjoy his little reactions so, Phainon was so responsive to every small action he did, it only made Mydei want to tease him more. Slowly, he licks the tip of Phainon’s cock, feeling something slimy and sweet across his tongue. Even slower, he brings his tongue up Phainon’s shaft, tracing the outline of his veins. At one point, his teeth accidentally bite down on his penis, not hard enough to injure, but certainly enough to cause pain. Phainon winces, and jerks so hard backwards that his head slams against the wall.

“I’m fine!” He says hurriedly, feeling Mydei pause in hesitancy. “That was… that felt too good, I overreacted. Sorry.”

An interesting reaction, so he liked that? But it was an accident. Intentionally, he lets his canines nick him again, and Phainon groans so hard that his penis twitches and squirts a little into Mydei’s mouth.

“Mydei please… please… I’m going to cum.” Phainon whimpers, his voice unusually high-pitched, like he’s doing everything to hold himself back. “Please… take it out of your mouth. I don’t want to come on your face, I don’t deserve to.”

Mydei raises his eyebrow. He’s not a delicate maiden and he wouldn’t mind if Phainon came inside his mouth, but since it’s his first time, he doesn’t know what’s normal and what’s not normal in such a situation, so he

decides to respect Phainon's wishes. He slides his mouth out of Phainon's penis smoothly, leaving a thin line of precum between them. Mydei stretches the jaw, feeling the ache, and experimentally runs a tongue across his teeth, still feeling the slick, sweet taste stuck on them.

Phainon makes a noise that can barely be called human. When Mydei looks at him he finds him clutching onto the walls for dear life, like he's literally going to collapse at any moment if he lets go. His face, no, his whole body is red, the golden tattoos on his neck and chest almost glowing in the contrast. Phainon looks at him and quickly closes his eyes, like the sight of Mydei on his knees, looking up at him with swollen lips, hair a mess, smudged eyeliner still on his face, licking Phainon's precum off his teeth is going to make him ejaculate immediately, on the spot.

"I'm going to cum… will you kiss me?" Phainon asks shyly, eyes still screwed shut.

Mydei sighs and stands up, feeling the wet pants stick to his thighs uncomfortably. He's already done so much, what's one more request? He presses his chest against Phainon and grabs onto his chin as he kisses him hard, almost violently, teeth clacking together at the impact. Phainon moans right into his mouth, tongue lapping across Mydei's lips and teeth as though it was covered with the sweetest nectar. Right as he does so, Mydei feels something warm splash across his feet, before it is quickly swept away by the running water.

Phainon is shaking like a chihuahua, heavily breathing like he might pass out. "Mydei…" he murmurs again, damp bangs hanging over his eyes, obscuring his expression.

Mydei pushes them back over his forehead, revealing blue eyes that look like they were close to filling up with tears again. "I left a towel and a change of clothes for you." He says, before walking out of the shower.

Phainon finishes his shower wordlessly, stepping out in fresh clothes and damp hair to let Mydei have his turn. After Mydei bathes, finally feeling

like himself in a clean t-shirt and track pants, he finds Phainon lying on his bed like he owns it, texting on his phone.

Yeah, Phainon looks unbelievably hot when he bothers to dress fashionably. But Mydei still likes this Phainon best of all. The one with messy hair, fluffy from the shower, wearing the brightest coloured shirt Mydei owns (cobalt blue), and a pair of white gym shorts.

Mydei's heart swells with fondness, when he sees him like that, it's like nothing between them changed at all. Like they were still roommates, rivals, best friends.

But… best friends don't give each other blowjobs in the shower. Best friends don't lie on each other's beds.

"Mydei!" Best friends don't look at each other like they hung the stars in the sky, like the way Phainon is looking at him now. Phainon immediately stands up, putting his phone away, he practically skips to Mydei and hugs him tightly, pressing his face into the crook of his neck and taking a deep sniff of his shampoo and conditioner.

"I missed you." Phainon exhales.

Mydei stiffens, suddenly remembering that everything that had happened tonight was real. What does this make them, then? Certainly not friends anymore. But he's not even sure if what Phainon feels for him is really love, or just some passing infatuation he's mistaken for love. Then what? Friends with benefits?

Phainon seems to feel his hesitation, because he pulls away, worry entering his expression and dulling those bright blue eyes. "Mydei…?" He says cautiously, like he's trying not to spook a small animal. "Are you okay? I didn't hurt you… did I?"

"Don't insult me. As if that could hurt me," Mydei finds himself responding.

Phainon tilts his head to the side, Mydei is suddenly reminded of those cute videos of animals he enjoys sharing in his free time. “Then… Do you regret what happened?”

There is no word for ‘regret’ in the Kremnoan dictionary. But Mydei did stop to ask himself if that was the right thing, in hindsight, he probably should have pretended not to see it. But there was a part of Mydei that had wanted, at the time, that still wants it. He just didn’t know if it was safe for him to have it.

If say, what Phainon wanted was a friends with benefits relationship, Mydei didn’t know if he would be alright with that. To him, sex was a form of love, he couldn’t have sex with someone he didn’t love, and likewise he doesn’t want a relationship with Phainon that is just sexual, because he is so deeply in love with the man that it hurts.

Again, his bad habit of not answering when he didn’t have a concrete answer, because Phainon’s expression falls further.

“It’s all my fault, isn’t it?” Phainon says, looking like he’s about to spiral again. “I should have controlled myself, it is your house, after all. I should have known better. I just… I couldn’t help it. You looked so good today, Mydei, that when I saw you all I could think about was wanting to rip your clothes off. And then you gave me a ride on your bike, and all I could think about was how wrong it was for me to get a boner! Did I ruin it? Did I ruin everything?” Phainon’s eyes start to fill with tears again.

“No, that’s not-”

Mydei doesn’t even get to finish his sentence.

“I’m the worst person ever, aren’t I? I told you I loved you, but all I’ve done was kiss you badly and made you give me a blowjob. I can do better, I can be good to you, don’t leave me.”

“You didn’t *make* -”

“I can fix it, I can do better. Let me prove it to you.” To his horror, Phainon starts trying to pull off his pants.

“Stop…” Mydei says, pushing him away weakly, he doesn’t want a blowjob from Phainon, well, actually he kind of does. But obviously not in this situation.

Phainon stops, on his knees, looking up at Mydei with what can be considered a truly pathetic expression. “I fucked up again… didn’t I?” He looks away with a bitter expression. “You said before that there was nothing I needed to change about myself, but that’s not true, is it? I’ve done so many things wrong already. It’s just… no matter what I do I don’t know what to do to make you love me back…”

Mydei frowns, it seems that they are severely misunderstanding each other. “Phainon… I think we need to talk.”

Phainon scoffs, still not making eye contact. “I don’t know if I want to do that right now. Saying that line only means that something bad is about to happen.”

He’s sulking, again. It’s kind of cute, but Mydei’s not in the mood to deal with it right now. Smiling the kind of smile that shows Phainon is seriously in trouble, he kneels down to be on the same level as him. “Deliverer. Sit down or I’ll *really* get pissed off.”

There’s something in his voice that means business, because Phainon turns a little pale, taking a seat on the bed like he was ordered to.

“Good boy.” Mydei praises without thinking, seeing a noticeable shiver pass through him. He takes note of that for later.

Now that Phainon is finally quiet and listening, Mydei sighs, knowing that he can’t avoid the conversation ahead any longer. He normally has no trouble speaking his mind, but he feels nervous about this. After all, it is hard, entrusting his heart to someone else. Even if that someone is Phainon.

“If I seem… unaffected, it’s because I’m actively making an effort to be.” He starts. “Your confessions, I have not been able to stop thinking of them. I only insisted that we wait because I need some time to sort my feelings out.”

“Can you tell me what’s on your mind?” Phainon asks, he almost reaches out for his hand but stops shy of touching it, too afraid of being rejected again. “You’re usually so straightforward that it makes me… anxious when you don’t speak frankly.”

Guilt surges through him again, the nerves Mydei is feeling right now must be amplified tenfold with Phainon. Sitting there, having poured his heart out to his best friend, not knowing if he reciprocated. Scared or not, he can’t keep doing this, can’t keep torturing him like this. Mydei takes a deep breath, and turns around to face his problems head on.

“I am just confused,” He admits. “And worried. Your feelings are not unreciprocated, but I just don’t know what to think. You decided you liked me so suddenly, what would I do if you decided just as quickly that you didn’t like me after all? I can’t go back to being friends after that.”

Phainon laughs dryly. “And I can’t go back to being friends after what we just did. Mydei… what made you think me liking you was ‘sudden’? I think even Hephaestion could tell that I was very much into you, and only you.”

Mydei blinks blankly at him. “If you liked me, why would you ask me for dating advice? And you said your type was ‘me, but not me’.”

Phainon winces when he thinks about his past behavior. “I guess I brought that on myself, I was so stupid.” He runs a hand through his hair, fluffing it up even more. “I think I was always into you, even when we were roommates. I just never considered the idea that I could actually have you. You seemed so out of my league.”

“The snowy prince thinks I’m out of his league?” Mydei says with a wry smile. “And here I was thinking the same thing.”

“Mydeimos,” Phainon gapes, he can accept a lot of things but he’ll never accept Mydei thinking that Phainon of all people is out of his league. “If you ever say that again, I’ll have to start a competition with you over who can compliment the other more. And I assure you, I will win.”

Mydei grimaces. “No need.” He mutters under his breath. “And I would win.” Never happy to let Phainon get the final say in anything.

“So…” Phainon asks again, a little hesitant, a little more nervous. “Now that you’ve seen my ugly side, does it change how you feel about me? That, you know, I’m not as perfect as everyone thinks I am.”

Mydei laughs, not unkindly. “I never thought you were perfect. I said, you were perfect as you are. The annoying, imperfect you who competes with me over stupid shit and sets the kitchen on fire even though he actually can cook. The Phainon I know who works harder than anyone else to achieve his goals, who aims for perfection because others wish it of him, who gives too much of himself to other people at his own detriment, who feels everything so deeply and sincerely. You never needed to change, because in my eyes, you have always been enough.”

He finishes his speech, finally getting the courage to look at Phainon in the eyes again, Mydei feels a little embarrassed, putting his heart out on a silver platter like that. But instead, he finds Phainon crying again, quietly, subtly, a single tear drips from the corner of his eyelid and trails down his cheek.

“What is it this time?” He asks, reaching out a hand to wipe it away. He’d seen Phainon cry more times tonight than he has in the past two years. Did he really fall in love with a crybaby? “And don’t say something brainless like ‘I didn’t know you could be so eloquent’.”

“It’s just…” Phainon’s bottom lip quivers. “How can I not fall in love with you, after you say something like that? You won’t say that to anyone else, will you? You’re driving me crazy.”

Phainon inches forward, as if to wrap himself around Mydei again, and Mydei sighs and lets him, resigning himself to being the object of affection for a really clingy oversized puppy.

“You’re really driving me insane.” Phainon repeats, hiding his face in Mydei’s neck again. “When I met Hephaestion I got so jealous, I realized that I wasn’t anyone special to you, just another one of your friends. Then you came and looked after me when I was sick, and I just finished jacking off to the thought of you, and I was acting so strange because I just realized I loved you so much and you are so nice and the thought of losing you to someone else made me crazy.”

“That is…” Mydei says, at a loss for words. “That is a lot of things to be worried about.” Phainon masturbated while thinking of him? Was that why he was so flushed and sweaty when he came to visit?

“I know!” Phainon whines. “You’ll make it up to me, right?” He grabs onto Mydei’s shirt even tighter.

“How do I do that?”

“Clearly since you said I’m perfect as I am you need to date me!” Phainon says. “Please? I can beg if you need me to.”

Mydei chuckles again, maybe it’s his taste that is fucked up because he can’t help but find the Deliverer really charming. “You don’t need to beg.”

“Then you’ll seal that promise with a kiss? Can I kiss you? And hug you?”

“You can just kiss me Phainon, no need to ask.”

And Mydei has never seen anyone dive in with such enthusiasm, no hesitation, just desire. He swoops forward, capturing Mydei’s lips with such passion and force that Mydei falls backward onto the bed, unable to do anything but lie there and let himself get kissed senseless by Phainon.

Phainon devours him, kissing him like he doesn’t ever want to stop, like if he stopped kissing Mydei he would die. His mouth opens naturally to let Phainon in, where he licks the inside of his cheek, his gums, his teeth. Slobber escapes the corner of their conjoined mouths, trickling down Mydei’s chin into the mattress.

The sound, the quiet, breathy moans, the heat in the air, it was almost too much.

Phainon releases him after titans knows how long, face flushed, lips red and glistening. He lifts up the corner of his mouth, tongue catching on one of his canines as he does so. It's the first time Mydei realizes how sharp they are. He licks his own lips, tasting blood alongside a sharp pain.

He bit him, Phainon had bit him. Clumsy fool. Yet Mydei couldn't say he disliked it.

"Mydei…" Phainon whines again, shuffling forward. His voice drips with something sickeningly sweet. In their current position, Mydei is flat down on the bed, legs swinging off it, while Phainon is seated on top of him. When Phainon shyly shifts his position, Mydei could *feel* what's going on before he even says it. "Mydei… I'm hard again."

Of course this man who is skilled in everything also has a beastly cock. He shouldn't have expected any less.

Mydei feels exhausted already. He loves this man, supposedly. And they say you can't choose who you love, clearly.

Mydei closes his eyes, feeling his own cock twitch in interest. Is it not enough that Phainon already took his first kiss and his first sexual experience, now he wants to take his virginity on the same night? But Mydei has a feeling that if he says it out like that, it will only make the puppy hornier and then he can say goodbye to sleeping.

Not to mention… he'd probably want to top, and Mydei doesn't know if he's ready for that yet.

"You're not ready." Phainon says, Mydei clams up. Is he going to have another breakdown? Start begging? What tricks will Phainon pull to get his way this time?

Instead he leads down, a soft smile on his face that makes Mydei's heart race. He brushes Mydei's hair away from his face gently, and plants a soft

kiss on his nose, then on his eyelids and forehead.

What is this… what is this devious new strategy? Mydei feels heat rise to his face and refuses to go away. Normally he would turn away and retreat somewhere where nobody can see his face, but he feels exposed, naked alone here with Phainon, in his bedroom, and nowhere to run or hide.

“You’re cute, you know. You wear your expressions on your sleeve.” Phainon tells him.

How *dare* he call him cute! Mydei is not cute, Mydei is not some… small… cute… thing!

“Shut up!” Mydei says, voice lacking its usual fire.

“Okay.” Phainon agrees readily, leaning down to kiss him on the lips. This time, he doesn’t breach the surface, his kiss is soft, reverent, a chaste press of lips to lips.

“I really love you, you know.” Phainon whispers. Mydei’s breath hitches and he stares at the ceiling, not trusting himself to speak right now. His face must be red as a pomegranate, he can feel the heat on his cheeks without being told.

“I told you to shut up,” he says weakly, pretty much giving up. Because he believes it, after all he has seen tonight, he really believes it. For once, the argumentative voice in his head who tells him to doubt everything he’s heard is silent.

He should say it back, after all, Phainon has poured all of himself out to him, the least he could do is show his heart as well.

“Phainon, I… I…” Gods damn it, why can’t he say it? How can Phainon think he’s perfect because he’s clearly not, he can’t say anything when it really matters. Love… the Kremnoans didn’t have a word for it, love is an all-encompassing devotion, an acknowledgement that a person is a part of your soul, forever. With time, he’s sure Phainon will become an

irreplaceable part of himself, but now, when things are so raw? He’s not sure, not to the level of ease and certainty that Phainon is, at least.

“It’s okay, I know.” Phainon cuddles close to him on his side, resting his head in the crook of Mydei’s neck, his soft hair tickling his shoulder. “I’ll wait until you’re ready. I’ll wait as long as you need me to. There’s nobody else for me, only you, Mydei.”

Mydei’s breath hitches, devotion. That’s what Phainon had offered him on a silver platter. Someone with so much love to share decides to choose him, of all people, for some reason. His heart feels so full that it’s close to bursting, and it still feels like a dream.

“Thank you,” he tells Phainon, a little stiff, a little formal. “I… I’ll be a good boyfriend to you.”

He hears Phainon’s breath hitch, and the body that had been clinging so tightly to him before shifts imperceptibly. Noticeably, Phainon moves his entire lower body away from Mydei.

“Let me guess… you just got harder?”

Phainon’s voice comes out in a whimper, softly like even he knows it’s embarrassing. “If you know then stop bringing it up!”

Chapter End Notes

> Good luck to all of you for your Phainon pulls <3 if he comes home early for me I'll post chapter 3 of him having hot sex with Mydei! If he doesn't... I'll still write him having hot sex with Mydei but after my crash out.
>
> Edit 02/07/2025: my phainon pulls went horribly y’all hot sex with Mydei has been postponed 😭

Chapter 3: Together

Chapter Summary

> Phainon switches on the dining room light and finds a plate on the table, covered with cling wrap. On closer inspection it appears to be one of his favourite dishes. On a sticky note are instructions on heating it up, written in Mydei's familiar penmanship.
>
> Oh, alright, Mydei made him dinner.
>
> Okay cool, there's a cute doodle of a chimera on the sticky note.
>
> Oh there's also dessert in the fridge once he's done eating.
>
> Phainon loves this man so much he's going to die.

Chapter Notes

> Alternate title: Hot Sex with Mydei
>
> This chapter in a nutshell be like:
> Mydei: You're the most jealous man I know
> Phainon: You know other men???
>
> I initially wanted to write this as just a smut bonus chapter but let me just yap about them being disgustingly in love first.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For the past 3 months, Phainon has been living his best life.

His best life included Mydeimos reciprocating his feelings, moving out of that crowded, smelly frat house and into a two bedroom apartment with Mydei, who is his boyfriend, and having lots of hot sex with his beautiful partner, Mydei.

Did he mention that he and Mydei are dating?

Although the change in living arrangements brought with it a significant rise in his monthly expenses, Phainon doesn't struggle much for money. Aglaea had been so satisfied with his first ever modelling shoot that he's now hired as one of her part-time models, and she pays well, almost too generously, in fact.

"Some extra money to spoil your lovely boyfriend," She says with a smile when Phainon receives his latest paycheck.

"Does he want a job? I still need an extra male model for that swimsuit shoot next weekend." Cipher says, eyeing the lockscreen of Phainon's phone. It's a picture of Mydei, taken when they were at the Okhema fun fair. Mydei is holding a plushie of the grey chimera named Coconut Beagle, expression bemused. Phainon has applied a filter which gives him cat ears and whiskers. He gains 10 years of life everytime he looks at it.

Phainon angles his phone away so that she can't see it, glaring at her until she eventually backs away in defeat.

"Okay, okay," She says, holding her hands up in defeat. "You really are a jealous doggy, aren't you? I wonder how your boyfriend feels about it."

"It is Phainon's first relationship, after all. It's normal for young people to… dislike sharing." Aglaea defends him, albeit with a knowing smirk.

Phainon laughs it off, but the remarks, said in jest, do make him self-conscious. It has been months since they started dating, and Mydei has never made any indication that he has eyes for anyone other than Phainon, but still he cannot help feeling so possessive to the point where he doesn't even want to show other people pictures.

Can you blame Phainon? His boyfriend is so gorgeous, so effortlessly sexy that it's not inconceivable that he might captivate others as much as he has captivated Phainon. So yeah, he might be a bit of a gatekeeper, but he feels perfectly justified in doing so!

By the time Aglaea releases him from the shoot, it is really late. Luckily tomorrow is a weekend so he doesn't have to get up early for classes. She's always thoughtful, arranging his schedule in a way that doesn't interfere with his studies.

When he arrives home, to the apartment he shares with Mydei, he finds the living room dark and empty. Today is their 3 month anniversary and he had been hoping to have dinner together with Mydei, maybe cuddle and watch a movie, maybe even have sex. But, Phainon tempers down the disappointment, it is his own fault for being late.

Whatever, his stomach is growling, he hasn't eaten and Phainon tends to get a little cranky when he's hungry, so he heads to the kitchen first. He's no longer banned from cooking, but Mydei still likes his kitchen a certain way, so Phainon does his best not to interfere. He'll just make a cup of instant noodles to fill his stomach.

Phainon switches on the dining room light and finds a plate on the table, covered with cling wrap. On closer inspection it appears to be one of his favourite dishes. On a sticky note are instructions on heating it up, written in Mydei's familiar penmanship.

Oh, alright, Mydei made him dinner.

Okay cool, there's a cute doodle of a chimera on the sticky note.

Oh there's also dessert in the fridge once he's done eating.

Phainon loves this man so much he's going to die.

He paces the room, head in his hands, as the food heats up, because he can't control the flood of emotions in his heart and how strongly he feels for Mydei. He thinks he might have cried a little bit too when he scarfed down the meal like it's the best food he's ever had, whether because it tasted amazing or because he just loved Mydei so much that he didn't know what to do with himself was anyone's guess.

After his dinner Phainon cleans up quickly and goes to knock on Mydei's door to thank him for the meal. There is no response from the other side, even after one or two knocks. Phainon contemplates if he should just enter regardless. It was considered especially rude in Aedes Elysia to enter a closed room uninvited, but Mydei had stated before that he grew up in a cramped dorm surrounded by other men, so it was fine to just let himself in whenever he needed something. It's a fact that Phainon still finds himself getting jealous of from time to time, because what do you mean Mydei grew up in close proximity to other men???

Ultimately his desire to see Mydei outweighs his sense of propriety and Phainon turns the doorknob cautiously. It swings open silently without a hitch.

"Mydei?" Phainon whispers as he steps in. It's quiet, peaceful, only Mydei's bedroom lamp is on. Phainon is more than familiar with Mydei's bedroom, considering he probably spends more nights here than in his own room. The room is as neat as ever, books properly aligned on their shelves, guitar upright on its stand, polished and gleaming, bed sheets tucked in except for the part that Mydei is lying on.

Phainon feels his breath catch when he sees Mydei lying on the bed, he's sleeping shirtless as usual, boxer shorts instead of his usual track pants, perhaps because it's hot in the summer. If gods walked among them disguised in human form, Phainon thinks Mydei would be one. He looks absolutely unreal, especially when he's vulnerable like this. He's lying on his side, bare back exposed to him, Phainon's fingers, light as air traces the red of his tattoos as they swirl around his scapula and thin to a point on his lower back. He stops himself before they continue under the hem of his boxer shorts, he probably shouldn't do this while Mydei is asleep.

He sighs internally, he probably should let Mydei get his rest. After all, his boyfriend wakes up earlier than him everyday and even makes him breakfast.

He walks around to the front and his heart melts when he sees that Mydei is hugging his Beagle Coconut plushie. That warm feeling is quickly replaced by jealousy though, because how dare it get hugs when Phainon is

suffering, *suffering* from Mydei deficiency. He can't believe the plushie he won to impress Mydei has betrayed him this way. Its devious expression, which they both thought was cute at one point, only seemed to be mocking him now.

Phainon, his boyfriend Mydei, and Beagle Coconut the traitor.

Maybe Mydei would forgive him if he stole one teensy, weensy little kiss? It is their three-month anniversary, after all.

Phainon leans in close, feeling Mydei's warm breath brushing his nose. His lips touch the tattoo on his cheek, light as butterfly wings.

"Mm…" Mydei mumbles, stirring in his sleep. Phainon freezes, his face still inches away. Mydei had always been a light sleeper, based on all the times he yelled at Phainon for waking him up by working on his assignments back when they were just roommates, but Phainon was being so careful not to disturb him.

"Sorry…" Phainon apologizes sheepishly as Mydei's eyes slowly open, revealing brilliant gold. Mydei just blinks at him sleepily, not surprised by his presence but just needing a few seconds to wake up.

"You're back?" Mydei sits up languidly, and Phainon really gets to appreciate the flex of his abs as he uses his core muscles to pull himself up. "Oh… I fell asleep."

"I didn't mean to wake you up," Phainon says, still taking care to keep his voice low even though it probably doesn't matter anymore. "I just wanted to thank you for making dinner."

Mydei grimaces. "I was going to do more than make dinner."

"What do you mean?"

Mydei flushes, turning his head to the side. Phainon knows him better than anyone else and this seems to be the body language of when Mydei has more to say but is too shy to say it, and therefore, needs it pried out of him.

“Mydeiii.” Phainon starts in a sing-song voice. “What were you planning and why is my tie on your pillow?”

Mydei’s breath hitches, and Phainon knows that means he’s hit the jackpot. He had noticed it a little earlier when he leaned down to kiss Mydei. It’s one of the ties from Aglaea’s clothing line that she allowed him to keep after the photoshoot. Sleek and black with golden detailing and a sun motif on the neckline. It’s meant to be worn circled twice around the neck, with the knot hanging loosely between the collarbones. He remembers the first time he showed Mydei the photograph from that particular shoot, Mydei had stared at it for a moment too long, face turning red. And then later that night he had the most back-breaking sex of his life.

Phainon knows that seeing this tie tonight could only mean good things.

“Nothing,” Mydei starts, almost on instinct, before he cuts himself off with a sigh. “I mean… I was trying to surprise you… since it’s our 3 month anniversary.”

“You remembered?” Phainon asks, feeling deliriously happy that Mydei would care about silly things like monthiversaries that even he admits can be a little much.

“How could I not? You keep bringing it up non-stop.” Mydei grumbles.

“That’s because I’m just so happy to be with you!” Phainon says cheerfully. “Being your boyfriend is like a dream come true for me, so I just want to celebrate every milestone like it’s a big deal. Do you think it’s stupid? I’ll stop if you think it’s stupid.”

Mydei’s face softens, he reaches out to entwine his fingers in Phainon’s hair and he lets him, head turning slightly so that Mydei is practically petting him. “It’s not stupid. I like that you’re very open with your affection. I just… sometimes feel bad that I’m not doing the same for you.”

Phainon tilts his head, genuinely confused. “Why do you say that?” Look, sometimes Phainon can be a jealous freak, but that’s totally his fault. He has never doubted Mydei’s love for him. He can taste it in Mydei’s cooking, the

way he memorizes exactly how Phainon likes his coffee in the morning, and even the way he lets Phainon win an extra round in the boxing ring if he knows he's having a bad day.

"Every day you tell me you love me… but I rarely say it back."

"Mydei, you love with actions, not with words." Phainon reassures, kissing his shoulder, his neck, the mole behind his ear that even Mydei himself probably doesn't know is there, his little secret. "You always know exactly what to do when I'm feeling bad and you notice the little details that even I don't realize are there. I'm more than happy being the clingy one in our relationship."

That makes Mydei chuckle a little bit, his shoulders relaxing. "You're… not the only clingy one."

"Oh?" Phainon says, realizing that he's suddenly become very, very invested in this topic of conversation. "Can you elaborate on that?"

Mydei glares at him, golden eyes shining in the darkness. "No."

Phainon is very familiar with Mydei to know when to fall back and when to push his luck, and this topic he knows he wants to see through to the end. "Mydei! Please! Little De, my pookie, love of my life, demigod of destruction of my cock, my-"

"Alright, stop, stop!" Mydei pushes him away with his palm while Phainon laughs. He knows his boyfriend can't stand these cringy nicknames. "I'll tell you, just… never say that last one again. It's just… you know how you've been getting popular lately?"

"What do you mean?"

Mydei just glares at him as though he's supposed to know, even though Phainon has no clue. "So you're telling me you have no idea that photos from your shoots with Aglaea have spread around campus like wildfire?"

Phainon shakes his head. He doesn't care about stuff like that. All he cares about is finishing his classes, completing his assignments, and then going home to Mydei. Everything else is just background noise.

Mydei huffs, seemingly irritated at his ignorance. "The other day a group of girls came up to me asking for your number. Apparently, they wanted me to hook them up with 'that handsome model from the law department that you're roommates with'."

Phainon is speechless. "I… they thought we were what?"

"They thought that we were just friends." Mydei says with a small sigh. "Apparently, it is not known that we are in a relationship."

"Oh." Phainon says, because what else is there to say? He talks about Mydei so much, and hangs off his arm any chance he gets that he would think this was fairly obvious to anyone with eyes.

"So…" Mydei says slowly. "I know I'm not the most… open and affectionate. But I wanted them to know you were mine. I was jealous."

This should make Phainon feel good, he should feel happy that this intense jealousy isn't just one-sided on Phainon's end. But all he wants to do at that moment is reassure Mydei that there is nothing to fear, that Phainon belongs to him and him *alone.* That he is not going anywhere, even if Mydei no longer wants him.

Jealousy comes from a place of insecurity, Phainon knows all too well. He admits he still has a lot of maturing to do when it comes to dealing with his own inadequacy and people pleasing tendencies which are, regrettably, not that easy to shrug off. But Mydei is different. Flawless, confident Mydei who always strides forward with his head held high, never looking back. Who, while he has his regrets, is determined to always seek a better way out, a brighter future for himself and his loved ones. Somebody like him should never have any reason to be insecure, not with him, not with how crazy Phainon is about him.

“Mydei…” Phainon starts, making his boyfriend look at him with an expression that indicates he just *knows* Phainon is about to suggest something he won’t like. “Can I get a collar that says ‘property of Mydei’?”

“No!” He growls.

“Permission to change my social media profile picture to one of us kissing?”

“Denied.”

Phainon wilts, if he had animal ears he is sure they’d be drooping right now. “Can I kiss you in public and walk with you to class holding your hand?” He asks as though he hadn’t been dreaming of doing that ever since they started dating.

Mydei pauses, seemingly contemplating it. “...Sometimes.”

Phainon mentally pumps his fist in the air, he has emerged victorious!

“If you want to model too…” Phainon starts reluctantly. “Cipher — the photographer from the shoot — has asked me multiple times for your contact information, apparently Aglaea showed her your profile picture and you’ve got the looks for it.”

“I’m not really interested in modelling.”

Phainon tries not to make it *too* obvious that he’s relieved. It really helps that Mydei isn’t interested in showing off his looks. He’d be way too distracting, Phainon wouldn’t be able to take it, his jealousy would go off the charts.

“Though… I’d give it a try if you wanted me to,” Mydei continues, Phainon shakes his head like a dog.

“No! You’ll be good at it, a little too good. If you become too popular I might have to tie you up.” He punctuates with a shrill laugh to try and hide that he’s being semi-serious.

“Right,” And if Mydei suspects he’s not actually joking, he’s nice enough to let it go. “Well, since you like the way I look, I was trying to take some sexy pictures to surprise you with. Unfortunately I got embarrassed and couldn’t go through with it.”

Sexy… sexy pictures? The speed at which Phainon’s cock jumped up at that statement needed to be studied.

“Mydeiiiii.” He says immediately.

“No,” His boyfriend shuts down immediately as though he’s read his mind.

But there are some things in life that cannot be compromised on, and Phainon will not let this one go. “Pleaseeee.”

“Forget it, they’ve already been deleted.”

If there is even a chance, even if it is a 0.00000001% chance.

“Don’t be mad!” Phainon says, immediately making a beeline for Mydei’s phone, lying unprotected on top of the bed. He knows Mydei’s password by heart, he’s just been respectful enough not to pry into his phone without permission. But this time, he doesn’t care if Mydei gets mad at him, or even kicks his ass 33 million times in the gym, he *needs* to see those pictures like he needs to breathe air.

“ *HKS!* ” He hears Mydei call out.

“Sorrysorrysorrysorrysorry-” Phainon chants, navigating to his photos and scrolling through them with a speed and hunger only possessed by a horny guy in his 20s. “You really did delete them,” He says blankly when he finds nothing. “This is even worse than the burning of the Castrum Kremnos libraries.”

“Stop talking nonsense.” Mydei snaps, snatching his phone back. “You didn’t think I’d actually be stupid enough to have the incriminating photos there?”

Phainon sulks at Mydei, any sexy photos he tries to take, even failed ones, would drive him crazy. His body is perfect, every muscle looking like it was sculpted directly based on Mnestia and Nikador combined. What expression would he be making? Maybe a dangerous smirk? A shy blush? A glazed faraway look that seemed to say ‘if you want it, come and get it’?

Argh, Phainon is driving himself crazy with the possibilities! If Mydei had sent him any photos when he was outside… there’s no telling what would happen. And if anyone had accidentally seen them on Phainon’s phone screen… well… there’s no telling what he would do to them.

This sight, Mydei’s beauty, Mydei’s perfection, should be for his eyes only.

“Then…” Phainon climbs on top of Mydei until he’s straddling him between his thighs. “Let’s recreate those photographs, since I didn’t get to see them.”

“What?” Mydei starts to say as Phainon grabs the tie, wrapping it around Mydei’s neck in smooth, practiced notions. At first he had difficulty tying it but well… Phainon is a fast learner. Two loops around the neck, knot hanging loosely between his collarbones. Phainon leans back to admire his handiwork.

“Gorgeous.” He praises. The black silk stands out starkly against Mydei’s pale skin and vivid tattoos. The decorative sun sitting on the left side of his neck, similar to the placement of Phainon’s own tattoo. The body of the tie drapes loosely along his abs, fabric moulding to the shape of his body. And although he loves Mydei and wants to treasure him, sometimes Phainon cannot resist the dark, almost sadistic feeling he gets to see this man absolutely wrecked. The satisfaction of knowing that someone so beautiful, someone so strong and so put-together, became undone because of him.

“I want to destroy you.” He says before he can even think twice.

“Hmph,” Mydei huffs, those golden eyes glow with defiance, with challenge. He’s not scared by Phainon’s dark side, in fact, he welcomes it. “Then let’s see who can make the other break first, Deliverer.”

“First one to cum loses.”

“How generous of you to propose a competition that you are disadvantaged in.” Mydei says with a smirk. He rubs his thigh against Phainon, the bulge in his boxers evident, and Phainon already wants to take him right here, right now. “Considering that the first time we fucked, you came before i could even touch you. And then you cried like a baby.”

“Can you blame me? I was so excited, getting to fuck the man of my dreams,” Phainon says, after all, it’s only right to prostrate oneself before a god. “But I learned a lot since then, and it’s you that will be begging for mercy tonight.”

Mydei just scoffs. “You underestimate my stamina, deliverer.” When he provokes Phainon like that, it only makes him want to try even harder.

Phainon does not wait for him to finish his boasting before he swoops in, claiming Mydei for himself. He starts with his mouth, those soft, warm lips that taste like honey, that drip feed praises and sinful words alike. He nips at Mydei’s bottom lip, licking off the salt iron tang of blood when he breaks the skin, running his tongue over the roof of Mydei’s mouth until his lover can’t even speak, can’t even breathe. And then he moves on, down to Mydei’s neck, leaves tiny bites all along his nape that make him moan, that make him gasp. Leaving skin reddened and puckered where his lips have staked their claim on him, marks that will last for days, turn into blue-black bruises tomorrow. Physical proof that Mydei is his.

Then Phainon’s personal favourite part, Mydei’s nipples. He takes his sweet time on those, kisses the perky pink nubs before taking them into his mouth, lavishing them with his tongue. He feels Mydei shudder from underneath him, good, his nipples have always been sensitive. Mydei huffs out a soft snort, his leg instinctively reaching out to kick him away. Ticklish, Mydei is surprisingly ticklish, which is another adorable fact about him that Phainon wants to gatekeep for himself.

“Nuh-uh, no moving.” Phainon says, pinning him down into the mattress with the weight of his entire body. Mydei shifts beneath him, warm and

firm, any effort to push him away only leads to Phainon pressing down with greater force.

“It’s… it’s uncomfortable,” Mydei complains.

“Really? Because your body is telling me something else.” Phainon allows the tip of his teeth to catch onto the sensitive nub of his nipple, just a little.

“Hngh…” Mydei groans, his hand gripping Phainon’s shoulder a little tighter before it relaxes again. His groin is pressing against Phainon’s thigh and he knows that Mydei is definitely rock hard, the boxers don’t hide anything. But stubborn Mydei refuses to show weakness, his grin is feral, and his gaze is still sharp and clear through his sweaty bangs.

“If you think a few kisses are enough to break my composure, you need to try harder.” That boundless confidence, it charms Phainon to no end.

“We’re just getting started, my dear Mydeimos.” Phainon shrugs off his shirt, only so they can even the playing field a little bit more. After all, Mydei is already all but naked, it’s unfair to him. A healthy sheen of sweat coats his body, catching the light in the hollow of his throat, over his clavicles, down the sharp lines of his abdomen, causing a slight glistening effect. Mydei’s pupils dilate, reminding him of a cat who found something they were very interested in

Mydei checks him out, not bothering to be subtle the way his eyes drag down Phainon’s torso, it almost feels like a caress, and he involuntarily shudders. It lingers on the thin trail of pale hair below his navel, disappearing under the low waistband of his pants.

“Like what you see?” Phainon teases. He is proud of his body, honed from years of hard work and discipline, and it’s gratifying to feel appreciated by his partner.

Mydei clicks his tongue. “I guess you’re alright.”

Phainon grins widely, devilishly. Mydei is still playing hard to get, that’s cute. Still acting like a king that won’t admit surrender. But his body is

betraying how he really feels. His fingers dig into Phainon's shoulder blades painfully, he knows there will be bruises tomorrow, but he likes that too.

It's only right that Mydei claims him in return.

He tightens his hold on Mydei's waist, leaning close enough that their bare chests almost touch, static electricity between the sliver of empty space between them. "You know you can touch, too, you don't just have to look."

"Are you sure you can handle that?" Mydei smirks, at first he simply runs his hand down Phainon's torso, his tough light and airy. It's slightly ticklish, and Phainon barely manages to hold in his laughter with a smile. But then his thumb presses down, rubbing in circles, its movements slow and intentional. From the ridge of his abs, tracing over the muscle, to the tip of his nipple which is sensitive from arousal. Mydei smirks as Phainon's breath hitches when he traces the outline of his tattoo, like a gold chain draped across his chest. His hand doesn't linger long there, opting to travel up to his neck instead and brush against the sun on his neck.

Mydei's fingers inspect the area thoroughly, rubbing and pinching as though looking for the best spot to make his claim. When Mydei leans up, pressing a soft kiss to the middle of the tattoo, followed by a sharp sting that would certainly leave a hickey, Phainon cannot control the soft whine that escapes from his mouth.

His cock thrusts violently in his pants, only restrained by his clothing. Phainon lunges forward, trying to nip back playfully, but Mydei ducks out of reach at the last minute. Instead, all Phainon has to show for his troubles is catching the tail of the necktie in his mouth, the one that Mydei is still wearing around his neck.

"You look stupid," Mydei smirks at the sight of it. "Like a dog holding its leash."

Phainon tilts his head, biting down on the fabric in his mouth. "Woof?" He says.

Mydei's lip quivers, he looks like he's torn between wanting to laugh or wanting to jump his bones. "You perplex me," he simply says. "I thought that was hot." He pulls Phainon down to his level by hooking two fingers under his choker. Kissing him roughly, wetly, passionately, like Mydei wants to eat him alive. His elbow is flush tight around Phainon's neck, pulling him even closer into his orbit. Mydei grinds against his thigh, his erection hard and obvious, the front of his boxers slightly damp from precum. Phainon knows he is the same, not doing so well at holding himself back.

"Let's raise the stakes," Mydei proposes "Clothes. Off."

"Want to see me naked that badly?" Phainon teases as Mydei tugs at the waistband of his pants with urgency, rolling them down over his hip bones, thumb caressing over the bare exposed skin. "Careful though, these pants are expensive. If you damage them I might have to punish you."

"Wouldn't want that. Then let me do it slowly…" The final word came out as more of a breath than a whisper, Mydei leans close to Phainon, tongue almost brushing the side of his ear, making Phainon shudder.

All of a sudden, Mydei moves, their positions are flipped before Phainon can even blink. He takes the tie off his neck, rolls it into a ball, and stuffs it into Phainon's mouth as he stares at him in utter confusion.

"Looks better on you than it did on me," Mydei smirks. Reaching for Phainon's pants, he pulls them off, inch by inch. As he does so, he lavishes Phainon's thighs with kiss after sinful kiss. His skin feels hot, seared in places where Mydei's lips touch. A shudder travels down Phainon and his toes curl, his legs almost kicking up with stimulation if not for Mydei holding him down.

Mydei finally reaches for his briefs, tugging them off in one fell swoop. Phainon almost groans at the relief when his cock escapes the tough confines, only for it to quickly turn to regret as Mydei takes it into the palm of his hand.

"It's not too late to give up, we can just call it my win."

‘In your dreams, Mydei!’ Phainon wanted to say, only to remember that he’s literally gagged by the piece of cloth in his mouth. He can only let out a muffled groan instead as Mydei rubs circles around the tip, his cock stiffening up almost impressively just by touch alone.

“Wow, you’re eager.” Mydei leans down, daintily tucks his hair behind his ear before licking a stripe down Phainon’s cock from tip to base. “But you also like a bit of pain, don’t you?” He catches his teeth on Phainon’s cock, dragging it slightly down his shaft. Phainon’s hips thrust upwards as his cock twitches, precum dripping from the tip. The moan he wants to let out is quickly swallowed, and Phainon chomps down on his makeshift gag so hard that his drool soaks the fabric and trickles down his chin.

Mydei’s smirk widens, Phainon can see how sharp his canines are and almost imagine how they would feel piercing into his skin. “Interesting.”

Phainon’s hands clutch at Mydei’s boxers, trying to pull them off him. It’s not fair, it’s not fair that he gets to tease Phainon so while he’s powerless to return the favour. He whimpers as the fabric gets stuck in position, refusing to budge. Mydei, taking mercy on his poor puppy boyfriend, obligingly moves his hips until the boxers slide off easily.

The sight of Mydei’s reddened, erect and weeping cock is enough to make Phainon drool even more. He looks down at Mydei, eyes wide and pleading, silently asking for permission.

“Why not,” Mydei says, coyly giving his cock one final kitten lick before straightening up. “It’s time for you to serve me. Let’s see if you’re all bark, Deliverer.”

Phainon spits the tie out of his mouth, mentally apologizing for the damp, soggy state of the fabric. He wastes no time in lavishing his lover with all manner of kisses, some reverent, some sloppy, all of them eager.

“Mydeimos, you’re beautiful.” One would think that Mydei would be used to his praise by now, yet the blond still gets a bashful look whenever Phainon compliments him, like he still finds it hard to accept. No matter, Phainon will keep worshipping him until he believes it. “So strong,” he

kisses his navel, feeling the abs flex underneath him, “And perfect,” now his neck, right above where his racing pulse point is. “And *you’re mine* .” He whispers into Mydei’s ear, low and guttural. Mydei shivers in response as Phainon nicks the tip of his ear with his teeth. “And I’ll *never* let anyone else have you.” His arm snakes behind his waist, grabbing Mydei and flipping their positions again. Mydei falls back onto the bed with a soft thump, his weight causing the mattress to rebound, and the breath gets knocked out of him with a soft ‘oof’.

“I know you’ll be so good for me. You’re going to cry on my cock, Mydei.” Phainon promises, lifting up Mydei by his thigh and resting it on his shoulder. Turning his head, he delivers soft kisses to the inside of Mydei’s leg. Mydei jerks, he’s always been tickling, Phainon clamps down on his hold even tighter so that he can’t shift away. From this angle, he can see Mydei’s entrance, open and inviting and already wet, eager for his cock.

“Ooh, you prepared yourself, for me?” Phainon says cheekily, brushing at the opening with his fingers. It’s slightly warm, clean, a little slick with lubricant and he loves the way Mydei clenches at his touch.

“Yes? Like… What did you expect?” Mydei growls, turning his head away in embarrassment.

The part of Phainon that enjoys making Mydei fall to pieces beneath him preens at the admission. It wasn’t easy their first time, Phainon was afraid Mydei wouldn’t enjoy bottoming. He was so tight, so reluctant, and the blonde man hadn’t uttered a word of complaint, but he knew he was in pain.

But now… Phainon inserts two fingers into that warm, inviting entrance, stretching it slightly as he parts his fingers. The way Mydei arches his back and groans is 100% genuine.

“Mydei… you took me in so well,” Phainon lets his voice drop an octave as he explores Mydei’s inner walls with his finger, gently probing at places he knows makes Mydei feel good. “I haven’t even done anything yet but you’re already leaking, so eager for me. I turned you into such a slut, all for me.”

He pushes in deeper, 3 inches, then 4. He curls his fingers and applies pressure onto the back of Mydei's prostate, there, he's memorized all the places that would make him feel good. It's only mathematics.

" *Fuck* ," Mydei whispers, voice cracking. He sounds so undone that Phainon could almost come right then and there, but he bites his own tongue until it draws blood, gripping himself to reality.

"You like that? Would you like my cock in you, Mydeimos?" He puts in a third finger, using scissoring motions as his entrance widens to let Phainon in. He pushes down again, on Mydei's G-spot, there.

" *Nng… yes* ." Mydei breathes out heavily through clench teeth, and this lets him know he's found the right spot as Mydei body violently jolts and nearly kicks him in the face.

"What did you say? I can't hear you," Phainon moves his fingers even more urgently, motivated by the small gasps that Mydei was letting out.

" *Haa…* Just - *Mngh* - Just *put it in* , you fucking HKS!"

Phainon's dick twitches violently, and he clenches his teeth through the exhale. He thinks a dribble of cum might have escaped at that, but it doesn't count, surely. Phainon can still keep himself together, barely.

"Say please."

"Mother *fucker* ."

Mydei sits up so aggressively that Phainon almost loses his balance, catching himself from tumbling backwards just in time. He stretches his fist out, like he wants to punch him, before Phainon can recoil, two fingers slip under his choker, pulling him so close, so quickly that their sweaty foreheads nearly crash into each other.

Phainon stops breathing, he just… looks.

Gods.

Mydei is… beautiful like this.

Blonde locks cling to his temples, sticky and messy with sweat. His chest rises and falls exaggerated by his heavy breathing. But it's his eyes that really take his breath away. Even his glower cannot detract from the fact that his golden pupils are clouded with lust, pupils so dilated they almost swallow the gold like a solar eclipse.

The bottom of his eyelids are reddened, swollen and slightly damp when he blinks, eyelashes catching on the tears in the dim room lighting. Tears… is Mydei really… crying?

" *Please* ." Mydei's voice comes out like an exhale, a wheeze.

Phainon doesn't think he can stop looking at him, even if he wanted to.

A tear slips past Mydei's carefully guarded defenses, rolling down his cheek. Mydei is looking at him like he's the only thing worth protecting in the world.

Fuck, he'd burn the world to see him like this again.

Phainon pulls his fingers out, the skin around Mydei's entrance puckering as he leaves, as though trying to get him to stay. Mydei groans, hips shifting to chase after him, already empty, already needing more. Phainon is quick to realign them by putting his hands on Mydei's waist, pinning him down.

"Wait! Don't move. I need to get a condom." He whimpers, the bedside table had never seemed so far away.

Mydei's voice cuts through like a blade, hoarse and deep.

"No."

Phainon's head snaps back, he thinks he might have hallucinated that in his lust filled haze.

"What?"

Mydei swallows, a bead of sweat rolls down his adam's apple and settles into the crook of his neck. Phainon can't stop looking at him.

"I want you. All of you. *Raw* ."

Phainon's hips jerk at that admission, heat surging through his body like his cock has become an entity separate from his brain. His arms, planted down on the mattress are the only thing stopping him from collapsing on the spot because… what else is a normal reaction when fucking Mydeimos asks you to take him raw?

"You're killing me." Phainon barely whispers in a shaking voice.

"Then die *inside me* ." Mydei orders, and like the command of a king, who was Phainon to refuse?

"Fuck." Phainon says, voice hoarse and wet like he's been crying. He shifts his hips, his cock finding the entrance between Mydei's slick, hot thighs and sliding in. Mydei's legs open wider, as his hole stretches to accommodate his girth. So warm, so inviting. Phainon pushes in deeper, feeling before he hears the groan rip through Mydei's throat, sound ragged and lustful and so… so undone.

" *Fuck … Fuck* Mydei you feel so good." Phainon can't help but say as he pushes deeper in, filling Mydei up until he can't go any further. They just pause for a moment as Mydei's breathlessly gasps to take it all in and Phainon desperately tries to keep it under control, at least just for a little while longer. He can't lose this contest, not now.

He needs to… he needs to.

"Move." Mydei commands again, his fingers are still wrapped around the choker on his neck and Mydei curls them and pulls. Phainon gasps at the tightening sensation around his throat, moving his hips as the friction between them becomes too good. With every groan and every thrust Mydei's grip tightens even more. Phainon's tongue lolls out of his mouth, drool slipping out from the corner of his lip, down his chin.

“You like it?” Mydei groans. “This necklace? You never take it off.”

Phainon nods, hair tips damp with sweat as they fall into his eyes, making them sting. “I love it,” He slurs, voice thick, eyes glazing over. Love it when Mydei grabs it like this and makes him do his bidding, love the sensation of being drawn impossibly close to Mydei like a force of gravity.

“Like being leashed- *aah.*… like a dog?” Mydei’s voice cuts off halfway as Phainon withdraws and thrusts in again, making Mydei’s entire body tremble. He can’t help it, it’s just that the idea excites him too much. The idea of a choker as a collar, Mydei staking his claim on him, holding onto it like a leash, commanding him, *owning* him.

“Like being yours.” Phainon clarifies, voice breathy and barely audible.

Mydei’s breath hitches, and his eyes widen for a second.

“ *Fuck…* ” He whispers as his whole body tenses under Phainon. “Good boy.”

“ *Hngh* … gods, *Mydei…* ”. His rhythm is erratic with how needy he is, how much he wants release. But even more than that he wants Mydei to feel good, wants him to cry underneath his touch until he can no longer speak. It’s not about the competition anymore, it’s about pleasuring him, about making sure that he gives Mydeimos everything he ever wants and more. That he fills Mydei up so good with his cum that he won’t ever think about other men ever again.

It’s scary how good the inside of Mydei feels without the condom, Phainon is scared he might get addicted to this. Addicted to the way Mydei turns his head into the mattress, cheeks flushed and red, groans so guttural it sounds like they’re being ripped directly from his throat. But Mydei is a guy too, so pregnancy shouldn’t be a problem, right?

Pregnancy… Mydei pregnant… Mydei carrying his babies.

Phainon hears a low groan escape his throat that frankly doesn’t even sound human.

Mydei gasps prettily as his eyes blow open. “Phainon… I… I…”

His walls are clenching around Phainon as he gets enveloped in another full body shiver. Phainon thinks he’s not going to last much longer as well, when he drags himself slightly out in order to thrust harder, deeper, the friction sends shockwaves through his entire body and he cries. “Mydei… *ahhh* - I’m gonna…”

Mydei’s whole body tenses as he orgasms violently, walls squeezing around Phainon’s cock one final time, stronger than ever before. At the same time, Phainon shuts his eyes as he can’t hold back his arousal anymore. He cums harder than he has ever done before inside Mydei, feeling him expand even more to accommodate him. So wet, so warm, so… so good. Phainon rides out his orgasm with a cry, not even caring if he’s being too loud. As for Mydei, well, he was alway quiet during orgasm, the type who would scrunch his eyes, moaning quietly as he allowed pleasure to overtake him. Even now, his muscles are tensed under Phainon, jaw clenched, and Phainon shouldn’t have any cum left in him but he’s still going, it almost feels like Mydei is sucking him dry.

Their bodies are still pressed together when Phainon gasps, the last waves of pleasure rippling through his body. Mydei inhales underneath him, relaxing slightly, one hand still holding onto the choker, the other entangled somewhere in Phainon’s hair.

That’s alright, he’d let him, they could mold into one, he would like that. Phainon lowers his head gently on Mydei’s chest, feeling the racing of his heart, the rise and fall of his chest as he breathes heavily. If time stopped now and this moment would last forever, he would be okay with that.

Phainon is happy. He never thought that it was possible to feel this happy. His arms tighten around Mydei as he holds tightly to him, unwilling to let go. He feels something warm and wet on Mydei’s abdomen, too much of it to be just sweat. It looks like Mydei had come too sometime during their joint orgasm.

But Mydei isn’t really the type to let himself linger. After some time, he feels Mydei shift first, as though motioning for Phainon to pull out. Phainon

sighs, forcing himself to move, feeling the slick on his skin as cum leaks out from Mydei's hole where Phainon had filled him up.

The idea of male pregnancy floats through his mind again, and Phainon feels himself blush. He was thinking such obscene thoughts, and they aren't even married yet! He definitely has to ask Mydei for his hand in marriage first, that is only right.

But one look at Mydei and he completely forgets what he wants to say. Perhaps Mydei is a god after all because he still looks unreal even after sex. His eyes are half-lidded, long dark lashes fluttering, stuck to his cheeks. His lips are puffy, swollen and bruised. His body is absolutely covered with bite marks and love bites, courtesy of Phainon. He can't help but linger upon the teeth marks on his neck, red and angry and attention-grabbing. Without thinking about it, Phainon leans forward and plants a reverent kiss on his lips.

"I win." Phainon says, grabbing Mydei as he tugs him onto the mattress. Mydei doesn't fight him, his bones are soft, muscles are trembling as he easily turns onto the bed to face Phainon, completely relaxed. "You orgasmed first."

"Wrong, I win," Mydei says sleepily, annoyingly put-together for someone filled with Phainon's cum.

Speaking of which, Phainon should take care of that. He grabs some tissues off the bedside table, motioning for Mydei to turn around. He makes sure to clean him thoroughly, gently, taking into account the places where the skin is sore and reddened. Mydei, normally stubborn to a fault, just quietly allows himself to be cared for. Perhaps it is the highest form of trust by Mydei to show his back, vulnerable and exposed, to someone else.

This idea fills Phainon up with love, and he can't help but lean forward, pressing a gentle kiss in between his shoulder blades. Still love does not equate to letting him win, and Phainon can't resist adding in a little "Nopee, you definitely lost."

Mydei flicks his head over his shoulder, glaring daggers at Phainon. “Come on,” He says dryly. “I know your biology isn’t very good considering you were mumbling about male pregnancy.” Oops, had he said that out loud? But… he could have sworn Mydei liked it, Phainon files that away in his memory for later. “But even you must know that our deal was who came first, and that particularly equates to ejaculation, not orgasm.”

Semantics, pedantics, Phainon lifts his torso off the bed, annoyed. “That’s cheating! You cheated!” Childishly, he bites Mydei’s nape in retaliation.

Caught off guard, Mydei yelps. He turns around to face Phainon, clutching the new bite mark on his nape like he’s been wronged. “It’s hardly my fault you cannot be bothered to clearly delineate the terms of our competition.”

He throws his arm over Phainon’s shoulder, intending to wrestle him to the bed. Phainon swings his leg over Mydei’s waist in return, pinning him to the mattress below them.

“Haha, you want to fight now? Speed or strength? I’ll warn you, I’ve got both.” He roars gleefully, practically sitting on top of Mydei on the bed.

“What I want to do is *sleep* .” Mydei hisses at him venomously. “Which I was happily doing before you interrupted me to have sex.”

“But it was great sex though.” Definitely top 3, in Phainon’s books, and he’s had some absolutely, back breakingly good sex with Mydei.

“It was pretty good,” Mydei admits grumpily. “You were definitely one of my better lovers.”

“What?” Phainon repeats, “Better what?” He drapes himself over Mydei again, trying to get a better look at his face to see if he’s joking or not. “Mydei, I thought I was your first. That’s what you said. Mydei… Mydei?”

“Hmph,” Mydei doesn’t respond, but Phainon can see the corners of his lips turn up into a smile despite his best attempts to hide it in his pillow. “Go to sleep, Deliverer.”

“Ugh,” Phainon sighs, lying back down on the bed next to Mydei. He is pretty tired, having spent most of the day in a photoshoot.

Mydei must be too, because it feels like he hasn’t been lying down for that long before he hears the deep, gentle breathing that indicates that Mydei has fallen asleep. It makes him a little envious, how easily his lover can fall asleep. It would seem that Mydei lives his life with such unwavering clarity that actions like shutting off his brain to sleep come naturally to him. In contrast to Phainon, who sometimes thinks too much and has a literal storm running through his head.

But being around Mydei helps.

Just being close to him helps in a lot of ways.

Phainon lies on his side, thoughts quiet, staring at his lover’s bare back. The soft light from outside paints faint shadows over the curves of muscle and bone. Mydei has his arm curled under his pillow, waves of blonde, fading to red, falling around his shoulders and the nape of his neck.

Strong. Phainon thinks.

Phainon reaches his hand out quietly, touch light like butterfly wings as he traces the vertebrae of his spine, one by one. Mydei shifts slightly, always a sensitive sleeper, but doesn’t wake up.

Mydei is his anchor. His fortress. His safe harbour in a chaotic world.

He loves him so much that sometimes it feels unbearable, like it’s going to burst out of his heart.

The bite mark Phainon gave him earlier still shines vivid red on Mydei’s nape, teeth marks imprinted on his skin. He feels a little bad about that, mostly because Mydei just took the bite without fighting back. For someone who seems so harsh, Mydei is secretly such a softy. Phainon feels pride that he’s one of the only few people who know that.

He reaches out, wanting to brush a strand of hair away from his shoulder, only for Mydei to suddenly turn around in his sleep and grab Phainon's air out of thin air with freakish precision.

Phainon freezes in place, heart racing. His hand caught in a death grip.

And then… Mydei just holds it, laces his fingers in between Phainon's and drops their co-joined hands back on the bed. He doesn't wake up, doesn't open his eyes, even his steady breathing doesn't falter.

That was… absolutely terrifying.That Mydei has such sharp reflexes, first of all, even in his sleep. The second, that he could have slapped Phainon's hand or pushed him away but he chooses to hold it instead. It's a sign of his absolute trust and devotion in him.

Trust that Phainon will be sure to cherish.

Phainon's thumb rubs against Mydei's ring finger, quietly gauging its width. Not for the first time, the thought of marriage slips into his mind. Phainon has never been sure about a lot of things, indecision is unfortunately one of his character flaws. But this, Mydei, is something he's absolutely certain about. He wants to marry Mydei, someday, if he would have Phainon. Sometimes, he feels like they're two halves of a whole, equally matched, something like soulmates. Perhaps in another life, they were.

But Mydei would probably panic if he asked now. It'll be too early for him to even consider such a thing. No, he doesn't want to scare Mydei off.

Mydei wouldn't accept an engagement ring, but perhaps if Phainon was able to find an antique from Castrum Kremnos. Some kind of signet ring, or jewelry they used for ceremonies, perhaps he could pass it off as a gift.

Yeah, that sounds like a good idea.

Phainon smiles to himself as his eyes close and he drifts off to sleep, still holding Mydei's hand. There is no rush.

They still have tomorrow.

And the tomorrow after that.

And the tomorrow after that.

There is an infinite amount of tomorrow’s ahead of them, and Phainon is looking forward to every one of them with Mydei at his side.

Chapter End Notes

> Posting this is like my therapy after finishing 3.4 story, oh Phainon my heart... you deserve the world.

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